POWER TO RECOVER

NA's Basic Text states in the Foreword:

The W.S.C. Literature Subcommittee, working in conference and as individuals, have collected hundreds of pages of material from members and groups throughout the fellowship. This material has been laboriously catalogued, edited, assembled, dismembered, and reassembled. Dozens of area and regional representatives working with the committees have dedicated thousands of man-hours to produce the work here presented. More importantly, those members have conscientiously sought to insure a "group conscience" text. In keeping with the spirit of anonymity, we, WLC, feel it appropriate to express our gratitude and appreciation to the fellowship, as a whole, especially the many of you who contributed material for inclusion to this book. We feel that this book is a synthesis of the Collective Group Conscience of the entire fellowship and that every single idea submitted is included in this work, in some form or another. Appropriately, this book is devoted to informing every addict: Just for today, you never have to use again. In the Introduction, it states: Everything that occurs in the course of NA service must be motivated by the desire to more successfully carry the message of recovery to the addict that still suffers. It was for this reason that we began this work. Throughout the compilation of this work, we have prayed: "God, grant us knowledge that we may write according to Your divine precepts, instill in us a sense of Your purpose, make us

may truly be Your work, not ours, in order that no addict anywhere need die from the horrors of addiction."

We must always remember that as individual members, groups, and service committees, we are not, and should never be, in competition with each other. We work separately and together to help the newcomer and for our common good. We have learned, painfully, that internal strife cripples our fellowship; it prevents us from providing the services necessary for growth.

We pray that we have been searching and thorough, so that every addict who reads this book will find the hope we have found.

It is with these same thoughts, desires, and prayers that this booklet, Power to Recover, is presented to NA.

This guide is intended to be a recovery tool for members who want to write the 12 steps of NA. We hope that you will find ideas and alternatives here that will help you in your search for peace of mind and a feeling of having done the most you can to take active part in your recovery.

The thrust of this booklet is to explore ourselves, through writing the 12 steps, and to better utilize the Basic Text. Furthering the understanding of the member about the disease of addiction, how it affected us prior to coming to NA, and how it is affecting us in recovery today.

Our disease is progressive, incurable, and fatal, and although we may not be using actively, the disease is always active. It surfaces in many subtle and sometimes not so subtle ways! The premise is that, "the disease of addiction is always spiritual maintenance to keep the disease in remission and produce ongoing recovery and personal growth." In the Basic Text it states "abstinence does not equal recovery", hence, the need to work the steps. This booklet or guide is to be used in conjunction with the Basic Text of NA. Many of the lines and phrases will be familiar to members who have studied the Text. Some things are paraphrased for a clearer meaning or to fit better in the context of this booklet. However, the content is remaining essentially unchanged.

sections contain key statements and ideas that relate to the disease of addiction, what it is, and how to recover on a daily basis.

This guide is the experience of sponsor/sponsee relationships and is dedicated to NA in the spirit of a loving higher power. "That no addict seeking recovery need ever die." As has been said in meetings, "take what you need and use the rest". Hopefully, this booklet will help just one member stay alive, justifying all the prayers, effort, and commitment that is contained herein.

In loving fellowship,

US

In NA, our first step states, "We admitted we were p... our addiction and that our lives had become unmanageable." This statement contains much more meaning to us in recovery than just the words of the step might imply. In this seemingly simple sentence are many elements important to addicts seeking recovery. This sentence, step, spiritual truth, is the foundation of which we begin to build our recovery, and it contains the key to NA's success. In the Text it says, "addiction is more than simple drug use." So the first step is more than simply giving up drugs. It is the foundation of our understanding, the disease of addiction and its varied elements.

For many years, the belief that substances were the cause of our problems was the predominate school of thought (i.e., you don't take substances and you're cured).

This is not the answer for us. We stopped many times and could not adjust, so we returned to using! In NA, we as a fellowship understand that there's more to it than just meets the eye. There is much more beneath the surface.

In this guide, we will explore our members' experience, strength, and hope on this little understood disease and discuss ways to treat it by first understanding what it is, and by then writing the steps as a part of our recovery program.

Medical research is beginning to validate what we as a fellowship have known intuitively for more than 35 years. Our great collective

repository of usable, valid knowledge and treatment modes available to mankind!

Many ask us what is an addict? How does someone get that way? When do we know we are addicts? How do we recover? Can we be cured? What behaviors are present in us? The list of questions goes on endlessly. We will attempt to explore these questions in depth in this booklet, hoping, but not daring, to assume we covered them all adequately.

NA MEMBERS TALK TO US

The following are direct questions, put to members of NA, and is reflective of the varied response gotten when we started this work.

THE QUESTION--What makes us addicts?

ANSWERS

1. "An addict is a man or woman who's life and thinking is centered in drugs, the getting and using and finding ways and means to get more."
2. "We couldn't stop using drugs."
3. "We inherited the disease somewhere in our past, and when we used, we got addicted."
4. "An addict is someone who has 3 flaws in them: Physical compulsion, mental obsession, and spiritual self-centeredness."
5. "You look at people who get high and it doesn't affect their lives. They can take it or leave it. I, however, am not one of those people!"
6. "A non-addict will stop if given sufficient reason. An addict will continue to use in the face of compelling, life threatening reasons not to use."

disease. Whey they use, it becomes active.

8. "An addict has the chromosomes that makes it possible for the disease to manifest in its active states."

9. "An addict's personality is already obsessive and compulsive, and their genes indicate that when they use frequently enough, with all these factors acting in synergy, the disease as we know it become active. Exposure to drugs and duration of use vary, but the people we see in meetings or 12th step work are all locked into the active cycles of the disease: obsession, compulsion, self-centeredness, using to get relief, and starting the cycle over."

10. "This question is stupid. What makes us addicts, or why we use is not important to us, when we honestly face the fact that we are! Our program deals with answers, not speculations, solutions, not questions. NA's 12 steps, 12 traditions, and our Basic Text all prove this program works. Look at us, our growth, our recoveries. That's all I need to know about addicts!" Some will continue to ask what makes us addicts, and we will answer to the best of our ability. We will continue to learn more, and we will be asked more probing questions. Science will make more "discoveries", and recovering addicts in NA will keep staying clean.

Never before in a man's entire history has there been a book on recovery from ADDICTION, until 1983 when the NA Basic Text was published. So really, we are all still learning about recovery, but now we have a "basis"--our Basic Text.

In this stepguide, we will try to compile these "gems" stripped of surrounding things that detract from their potency, and serve them up to you, the reader, seeker, recoverer, in "pure doses of recovery!"

Good Living Through NA

FACE IT

The statement, "Abstinence does not equal recovery," is a common theme in our literature and living experiences. The statement, "You take the drugs from a drug crazed addict, and what you have left is a crazed addict," is indicative of our dilemma.

We all have stopped using drugs for a while and have gotten temporary relief, and we felt good and powerful for a time. Yes, we were powerful over the external symptom of taking substances.

What followed this is something we all seem to be familiar with. This is the fact that we could not deal effectively with life, others, our feelings, reactions, ourselves, or our thoughts. We just had to find relief somewhere, and drugs were the only thing we had ever tried that worked for us.

We must, in order to achieve what we call recovery, not just abstinence from drugs, identify and change the "internal messages" and break the "external reaction" chains. We do this by stopping using and learning new ways of dealing with the internal dialogue and our emotional reaction to it and the resulting external expression.

We work the steps to gain insight into these "events" taking place in us and in our lives. A result of doing so is that we get "in touch with" the internal messages and examine our emotional reactions to

we are able to perceive patterns of external behavior that we can ... to change. From the very beginning, we are told, "don't use, and you won't get high." In the most simple way, this is what we mean by internal message, the emotional reaction, and the external result!

However, the absence of drugs in our systems still leaves these diseased processes undealt with or untreated. In NA, we believe our disease is physical, mental, or emotional, and spiritual in nature. If we take this literally, then two-thirds of our problem still exists when we stop the drugs. We must set up for ourselves, with the help of our groups, sponsors, and literature, a daily program of active participation in our recovery by living the spiritual precepts of NA. The dictionary defines precept as, "a rule of conduct, a guide or example." The 12 steps and 12 traditions are precepts, truth, examples of what works, proven effective, RULES TO LIVE BY!

In recovery, we must utilize these precepts to begin to understand ourselves, and to break the "internal message and reaction chain." We have to set up for ourselves an alternate system of behavior when we are confronted with the external things or internal feelings that always caused us to use. Then we can begin to find comfort, confidence, self-esteem, and take our rightful place in society, while we continue to heal emotionally and spiritually.

We are not powerless over our use of substances. We have power not to put them in! What we ARE powerless over is our reaction to having drugs in our systems. We are not powerless over people, places, and things. WE can CHOOSE to not be around people, not to go places, or

over is the internal message, emotional reaction, and the resulting external expression we may have when we go around old places, or hang out with old people. We do have POWER! We have power to recover. We can DO the actions necessary to produce recovery.

Don't USE, go to meetings, share your feelings, listen to others, work the steps, call your sponsor, pick up ashtrays, do service, make coffee, give newcomers a ride, go to the diner, get off your ass, follow directions, start a meeting, write literature, carry the message, learn more, grow more, pray more. All the above require your participation!

ACTION - RECOVERY

Please don't be HIP, SLICK, and DEAD. With Love,

US

P.S. "You can't save your ass and your face at the same time." "We suffer from fatal hip and terminal cool."

Quotes from the NA Basic Text

Our Basic Text gives us many statements --

disease is and how we can recover. In the Introduction, there are the following lines. "We have by no means found a cure for addiction. We offer only a proven plan for daily recovery. Substance abuse is too limiting a term for us, our problem is not a specific substance. It is a disease called addiction. Based on our experience, we believe that every addict, including the "potential addict" suffers from an incurable disease of body, mind, and spirit."

On page 1, we are told, "Addiction is a disease that involves more than simple drug use"; page 2, "We suffer from a disease that expresses itself in ways that are anti-social and make detection, diagnosis, and treatment difficult"; page 3, "We are willing to admit we are addicted." It would be insane to go back to the source of our physical addiction. Although physical and mental tolerance play a role, many drugs require no extended period of use to trigger addictive reactions. Our reaction is what make us addicts, not how much we used. Like other incurable diseases, addiction can be arrested"; page 5, "Those of us who don't die from the disease will go on to prison, mental institutions, or complete demoralization as the disease progresses. As addicts, we have an incurable disease called addiction which is chronic, progressive, and fatal. However, it is a treatable disease. Denial of our addiction is what keeps us sick"; page 6, "We realize we are never cured. We carry the disease within us all our

9, "We are men and women who have discovered and admitted that we are powerless over our addiction. The steps and abstinence give us a daily reprieve from our self-imposed life sentences"; page 10, "Our program is, in fact, a way of life"; page 12, "The progression of the disease was not apparent to us. Often doctors didn't understand our dilemma. They tried to help us by giving us dedication"; page 13, "Personality change was what we really needed. Although we are not responsible for our disease, we are responsible, however, for our own recoveries. The ultimate weapon for recovery is the recovering addict"; page 14, "We found we suffered from a disease, not a moral dilemma. We were critically ill, not hopelessly bad"; page 17, "Our only hope is to live by the example of those who have faced our dilemma and found a way out. Our addiction gives us a common ground for understanding. Our steps are our solution, our survival kit. Our steps are the principles that make our recovery possible!"; page 18, "We reached the point where we could no longer continue because of physical, mental, and spiritual pain. When we were beaten, we became willing."

Also on page 18 are two paragraphs which are very pertinent to recovery and necessary for us to grasp the full implications of NA's First Step, the key elements of which are as follows: "Our inability to control our use of drugs is a SYMPTOM of the disease of addiction. Denial, substitution, rationalization, justification, distrust of others, guilt, embarrassment, dereliction, degradation, isolation, and loss of control are all results (symptoms) of our disease." "We are

mental, and spiritual disease affecting EVERY AREA of our lives. The physical aspect of our disease is the compulsive use of drugs (only one of the physical aspects). The mental aspect is the obsession, or overpowering desire which leads us to using even when it has destroyed our lives (only one of the mental aspects). The spiritual aspect is our total self-centeredness (or self obsession)."

We don't get here in good shape. Many of us are atheist, agnostic, or believe that God has somehow deserted us or we are not worthy of God's love, or good enough to be cared about by God.

We have seen all types of members bet their lives on the principles of NA, because they had nowhere else to turn, and find a loving God that has given them "power to recover"! Many of us were at a place in our lives where we had no choice but to work the NA program, or die. We did not believe it would work for us and were delighted to find our disbelief was unfounded in reality. The spiritual NA precepts work for anyone who is willing to apply them, even if the individual does not believe that they will work!

The Text says, "Pride, fear, and procrastination often seem an impossible barrier. They stand in the way of our progress and growth. The important thing is to take action. Each positive move on our part will be matched with an unexpected opportunity. Real security will replace the physical ache and mental confusion we have experienced in the past. In time, many miracles will occur. Clean time speaks for itself."

we need for our spiritual well-being. It is alright for us to admit powerlessness. God is powerful enough to help us stay clean and enjoy spiritual progress. The answers we are looking for come to us. God is helping us get our house in order. We gain the ability to do what we once could not."

The "power-to-recover" is what we get by working the 24 NA precepts into our daily lives and in our dealing with others.

From the Text--"We find an indescribable joy as we start to learn to live by the (spiritual) principles of recovery." Spiritually refreshed, we are glad to be alive. We learn to respect ourselves. Life takes on a new meaning, new joy, a reality of being and feeling worthwhile. God helps us as we help each other. We are a vision of hope. We must always give freely and gratefully what had been freely and gratefully given to us. The message, however, is meaningless unless we live it. We are examples of the program working. The joy we have in living clean (walking our talk) is an attraction to the addict who still suffers. "If we had problems in the past, it is unlikely that simple abstinence will provide a solution. The ability to face problems is necessary to stay clean. We learn to keep the program first. Clean, we face the world together. Our common effort is recovery. Our experience reveals that working the steps is our best guarantee against relapse!

"We admitted that we were powerless over our addiction that our lives had become unmanageable."

Read the Text on How it Works - Stop at Step 2.

1. We start this step in the same manner that we start and close our meetings; with prayer. We get on our knees and get quiet and ask our Higher Power to give us the honesty, open-mindedness and willingness to do this step. Whenever we find that we are stuck and can't go on, we get back on our knees and pray again. This has helped most of us when we have found ourselves stopped and unable to proceed.

2. There are questions in the Basic Text in the Chapter How it Works, right before Step 1. These are the first things we write about. Answer these questions with at least 10 sentences a piece, describing our feelings about them as well. These questions will help us get in touch with the physical aspect of our disease.

1. Are we sure we want to stop using?

2. Do we understand we have no real control over drugs?

3. Do we recognize, that in the long run, we didn't use drugs, they used us?

4. Did jails and institutions take over management of our lives at different times, or did other people take care of us?

5. Do we fully accept the fact that our every attempt to stop using or control our using failed?

6. Do we know that our addiction changed us into something we didn't want to be, dishonest, self-willed people at odds with ourselves and our fellowman?

8. Have we hurt long enough to be willing to go to any length to stay clean?

9. Was reality so painful to us that we could not face life without drugs?

3. Define these words and phrases: your definition and a dictionary definition after your definition. Then write (at least 20 sentences) your feelings and thoughts about them and how it applies in your life today and before you came to N.A.

We	Admitted	Powerless
Addiction	Unmanageability	

4. Write your meaning in at least 10 sentences and then look up the definitions of the following words in a recent, large dictionary and write their meanings on paper. This is helpful to gaining a greater understanding of the words we hear in N.A. and to help us know what we are doing and saying and why. Please share your thoughts on paper that come to mind after you look up these words. What did you think they meant? How is that different now that you know?

Clean	Recovery	Addiction	Disease	Self-Will
Drugs	Surrender	Steps	Traditions	Control
Inventory	Principles	Obsession	Compulsion	Defects
Shortcoming	Honesty	Open-Minded	Willing	Acceptance
Reality	Fantasy	Willpower	Substitute	Insanity
Sanity	Symptom Using			

5. The following quotes are out of the Basic Text. Write about what they mean to you and how they describe your life and feelings, now and before you came to N.A. (at least 20 sentences).

1. "In N.A., staying clean has to come first."

our own lives, we open the door to recovery."

3. "We found we could not control our using, everything we tried failed."

4. "We could not stop with our greatest willpower or most sincere desire."

5. "When we were beaten, we became willing."

6. "We could no longer continue because of physical, mental, and spiritual pain."

7. "Our inability to stop using drugs is just a symptom of the disease of addiction. We are powerless, not only over drugs, but our addiction as well. We need to admit this in order to recover. Addiction is a physical, mental, and spiritual disease, affecting every area of our lives."

8. "The physical aspect of our disease is our reaction to taking drugs." (paraphrased)

9. "The mental aspect of our disease is the obsession and compulsion to use drugs or some other substitute."

10. "The spiritual aspect of our disease is our total self-centeredness or total self-obsession."

11. "We are not hopelessly bad, just critically ill."

12. "We are not responsible for having our disease of addiction, but we are responsible for our own recovery."

13. "Do we believe our disease is progressive, incurable and fatal, if we don't stay clean?"

14. "Until we let go of [illegible]
foundation on which our recovery is based is in danger."

15. "We are great ones for manipulating the truth."

16. "Help for us addicts begins only when we admit complete defeat."

17. "We begin to change when we can no longer stand our old ways."

18. "We do not just say the words of these steps we learn to live them, because none of these steps work by magic."

19. "Surrender to N.A. means we don't have to fight anymore."

20. "Do we want to find meaning and purpose in our lives, and leave our old selves behind?"

21. "It is not where we have been before coming to N.A. that counts, but where we are and what we are going to do about it."

We must be as honest as possible and not leave anything out while writing these steps, for they will not work for us if we don't apply the H - O - W of our program. Honesty, Open-mindedness and Willingness, together with the Action you are taking right now are the necessary elements to produce ongoing recovery in your life.

6. Why does the Text talk about: Being abstinent from drugs does not equal recovery. Becoming socially acceptable, employed, reunited with our loved ones, well dressed, and lots of money (external things) do not equal Recovery.

7. Is N.A. an inside job, or an outside job? Does it matter how we feel inside or how we appear on the outside?

8. Do we believe that we have to completely change our old ways of thinking and acting or go back to using?

have never done before to stay clean and recovering.

10. Do you want what you see in our program for yourself, if so, are you ready to work Step 2, to go on with your recovery?

11. What have you found out about yourself, the disease of addiction, and N.A. that you didn't know before?

12. Read Step 1 again in the text and write a summary of what this step means to you and what you have learned about yourself.

13. How do you feel about having done all this praying, writing and working?

Good? Bad? Don't Know?

So, congratulations, you earned it. We earn our recovery in N.A.; it does jump into us by sitting in meetings. We take actions such as this because we must actively participate in our recovery process. So, now, call your sponsor and get together with them and share this step. It does not matter that some of the things you wrote don't make sense! Don't erase, edit, or throw any pages away, because your sponsor should be able to help you make sense of it. After all, we don't need to be Pulitzer Prize winning writers to get this program!

So --- Good writing on Step 2.

NA Step 2 in Writing

"We came to believe a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity."

This step is the beginning of the process of going from powerlessness, to finding a power to help us in our recovery and as it says in the Basic Text. "The first step leaves us with a vacuum in our lives. We need something to fill that void." Step 1 leaves us with the need to believe in something that can help us with our powerlessness, uselessness, and helplessness.

As we have talked about in the First Step there is more to our recoveries than just putting down drugs, we need to change our ways of living! Many members skip over this step and therefore cause themselves undue frustration later in their recoveries. After all, if we are not insane, then how can we possibly expect to be "restored to sanity?" Hence, we must honestly examine the insanity that we admitted to in the First Step and surrender to the fact that, yes, the things we did and the way we felt, and the unmanageability of our lives proved to us that we were indeed a "touch off." Perhaps we could really use some assistance from somewhere that would really work for us!

The last sentence in Step 1 in the Basic Text says, "It's not where we were that counts, but where we are going that matters." If we are going to recover, then we must be going somewhere. The first sentence in Step 2 says, "The Second Step is necessary if we expect to achieve any sort of ongoing recovery." The Text further states, "We need to accept this step to start us on the road to recovery. The strength to move into action comes from this belief."

In writing this step, we try to examine what our insanity is and what it isn't and try to find out what a power greater than ourselves might be.

Some members have shared that, "The power greater than ourselves can be anything that we want it to be for the purpose of this step, if it has the following attributes: loving, caring, trustworthy, and having the ability to restore us to sanity. We need to have a power that works, not one that is unable to do the job." Some members use the group or Fellowship of N.A. With nearly 800 meetings and three quarters of a million of us staying clean around the world and more to follow, there seems to be some evidence that N.A. may be a power greater than our disease. The "We" in our steps may hold some answers for us. We stay clean, We recover, We don't do it alone, We work steps, We is a power greater than "I". The letter I is in the center of the word die, and that's what our disease wants for us. So when we say, "I can't, We can," we begin to understand "coming to believe!"

"We" can help restore me to sanity. The results of working the 12 Steps is a restoration to sanity, happiness, and fulfillment, and taking our place in life on life's terms.

Spiritual principles are the truth, and the truth is the truth, even if we don't believe it. N.A.'s spiritual principles (the 12 Steps and 12 Traditions) work even if we don't believe they will. If we just take the action and do them, they will work, we will believe, we will be restored, faith will become part of our lives. We often find that

just doing something relieves our fears and doubts about ourselves. If we sit on our duffs, we will never know whether or not we can do what we don't think we can, when we're just sitting there full of fear and self-doubt. Many of us were stuck, unable to get ourselves going. We have found that there is no better motivator than realizing that our lives are on the line and that to go backward is to die, or worse, live in the misery and insanity of active addiction. We are confronted with jails, institutions, hospitals, death, permanent insanity, crime, violence, prostitution, guilt, remorse, depression, anxiety, fear, paranoia and many more of the wonderful things that were part of our lives before we came to N.A.

So "give yourself a break", take the initiative, do for yourself what countless others have done before you. They came to believe a power greater than themselves would restore them to sanity. They took the action suggested. The suggestion is, work the Steps!

Read the Basic Text, How it Works, stop at Step 3 - Reread your First Step to refresh yourself on the things in it that you became aware of.

1. Get comfortable and pray for the willingness, honesty, and guidance. If you get stuck, pray again for the strength to go on. Prayer works for us, even if we don't know who or what we are praying to. Many members started praying to "whatever's out there." Feeling funny about it but doing it anyway, and they are clean today and "have come to believe!"

2. Get out your dictionary if it's not out already; we are going to define words again, Oh Boy! Fun, Fun, Fun. Don't let the 3 R's of our disease stop you - Relapse, Resentment and Reservations. Get into the 3 R's of the N.A. program - Reading, Writing and Recovery!

Write, in your own words, definitions of these words or phrases and follow with dictionary definitions. Then write about them and how they apply to you now and before coming to N.A. (At least 20 sentences a piece).

1. What is sanity to me?

2. How were/are my behavior, thinking or feelings insane?

3. Were the results of my life something I was proud of?

4. Do I believe I can be restored to sanity and feel better about myself?

5. What does Higher Power mean to me?

6. What does Lower Power mean to me?

7. Do you believe in a Higher Power, what is it?

8. Do I want a Higher Power in my life?

9. Do I really want to feel better?

10. Do I see the program working for others and do I want what they have?

11. Am I willing to go to any lengths to stay clean and get what this program offers me?

3. On page ~~87~~ 87 (~~6th~~ 6th edition) in "We Do Recover", are 2 paragraphs that talk about obsession and compulsion. Read them and write at least 20 sentences about your feelings about what it says and how your life is/was like that. The paragraphs start out, "We know well the things that make up true addiction."

4. What do you think the word "substitute" means in these paragraphs? Write about it (at least 10 sentences). Some substitutes are (sex, money, fast cars, sky diving, food, work, over achieving, approval of others, gambling, clothes, the list goes on). Anything we use to make us feel better, trying to use external things to make our insides feel better. Add any others you may think of.

5. The following quotes are from the Basic Text; write about them and how they apply to your life before N.A. and now (at least 20 sentences).

1. "Even when we admitted we needed help with our "drug problem", many of us would not admit the need for faith and sanity."

2. "Insanity is repeating the same mistakes and expecting different results."

3. Drug use, "At least part of the insanity of our addiction."

4. "The first thing we do in this program is stop using drugs. At this point, we begin to feel the pain of living without anything to replace drugs."

5. "This pain forces us to seek a power greater than ourselves."

6. "Our best thinking got us here, our best efforts resulted in even greater destruction and despair. At some point, we realized we needed the help of some power greater than ourselves!

7. "We began to see evidence of some power (in N.A.) that could not be fully explained. Confronted with this evidence, we began to accept the existence of a Power Greater than ourselves. We began to see "miracles" in our lives. We can use this power before we begin to understand it."

8. "Our understanding of a Higher Power is up to us. We can call it the group, the program, or God. No one will decide for us. We don't have to be religious to accept this idea. By keeping an open mind, sooner or later, we find the help we need."

9. "The process of coming to believe is a restoration to sanity. The strength to move into action comes from this belief. When our belief has grown, we are ready for Step 3."

6. What have you learned about yourself and the way the disease of addiction has affected you in every area of your life and affects you today?

7. Do you see areas in your life today where the disease is keeping you from growing and feeling okay? What are they? Remember, it is very <u>crucial</u> that we are as honest as possible with this particular question.

8. Read the step in the text, reread what you have written here, and write a summary of what the Second Step means to you and how you feel about it.

9. Do I see that I need to do more than just stop using drugs?

10. Do I want to go on to Step 3 and learn more about myself and N.A.?

Well, congratulations, you've made it through. It wasn't all that tough, now was it? After all, the drugs didn't kill us, so what's there to worry about? We can handle a little writing now and then if it will make us feel better, now can't we?!

Many of us got real tired of our disease leading us around by the "short hairs". We heard people say things like: "You can hang on the corner with the losers, or you can stay in N.A. with the winners." "I was so whimpy before I came in, I couldn't do anything for myself."

Well, you've really done something for yourself by writing these steps, and your fingers didn't fall off. So give yourself a break and call your sponsor immediately. Tell them they can relax, you did it and didn't use over it, and you need to share it with them immediately. "We are proud of You!"

With Love,

US

Jimmy

NA Step 3 in Writing

"We made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God, as we understood him."

Our Basic Text says, "The word decision implies action. This decision is based on Faith." The last sentence in Step 2 says, "When our belief has grown, we are ready for Step 3," It further states. "We found that all we needed to do was try. When we gave our best effort to the program, it worked for us, as it has worked for countless other." At the end of Step 1, it says, "It is not where we are that counts, but where we are going."

We probably have discovered, by now, that sitting still doesn't help us recover, and that it takes admittance, acceptance, faith, and action to get the good feelings of participating in our own recovery. If we don't take action, we can not expect to have any increase in our self-esteem and the resulting feelings of accomplishment and personal satisfaction. If the statement "fear is a lack of faith" is important to us, we might want to consider that somehow we must find the faith, strength, and hope to continue our recovery. The action we took to get clean and write the previous two steps has given us a better sense of our power to recover in NA.

Some of us have asked, "What is God as I understand?" Will I become holy? Will we become perfect? Do I need any special

understanding of God to work this step? Do I understand God? and many questions like these.

Some of us have asked, "Do we turn our life over permanently? Do we automatically do God's will? Do we have to get religious? What does turning it over mean?"

Some of us have had difficulty understanding this step because we tended to read things into it that just weren't there.

When we want to change, we make a daily commitment to doing the things that will help us achieve growth. Turn it over, write this step, gain some understanding. We do not do this completely or perfectly. Turning your life over to daily recovery is the most basic element involved in this step. The words "God, as we understand" free us of the necessity of having a God that I understand. This is not to imply that one day we will not have a loving spirit that we understand personally, or that this is not needed in our program. For the purpose of this step, the first time we approach it, "God, as we understand" may be seen by us as the power that we see in our meetings, and working in the lives of our members. That power that we have allowed to begin to restore us to sanity, and to keep us coming back to meetings, is the God, or power many of us first relied upon when coming to NA.

The Text says, "It is impossible to graft a new idea on a closed mind." No one has the right to tell you what you must believe, only that it is necessary to believe in SOMETHING, even if it is only the fact that if we don't "do" the program, our disease will "do" us in!

All the evidence we need is around us to let us know that this program works for those of us who work it. Sharing with

others can give us ideas about surrender, decision, and commitment.

Our first 3 steps have often been described by members with statements like, "Step 1 is I can't, Step 2 is We can, and Step 3 is I think I'll let Him," or Step 1, honesty, Step 2, open-mindedness, Step 3, willingness." Another way to say this is, Step 1 -identify the problem, Step 2 -- find out the solution, Step 3 -commitment to live in the solution.

The process of writing the steps for the first time is an active way for involving yourself in NA. It is a tool for you and your sponsor to begin to form a relationship based on trust, sharing, honesty, and caring. The steps also, when written, give recovery. It is interesting for members to look back at the differences in their awareness the second, third, fourth, fifth etc. times working through them. Please don't throw them away or burn them, as you will probably want to look at them again.

Most of us go through a lot of growing and changing from Step 1-Step 12. We need to continue to write and inventory ourselves as long as we stay clean. Heck, we detox for a year, and we wake up on many levels that have been asleep for years. As we begin to come alive physically, emotionally, and spiritually, we will need to take another look. We will see more, feel more, discover new areas to deal with. Our eyes, ears, body, mind, and spirit will be opened to us as we become spiritually ready for more to be revealed.

So we approach this step prayerfully, believing that we, too, can have all that this program has to offer us. Read the Text -- How it Works, up to Step 4, and reread your previous steps.

1. Pray for willingness to work this step, and ask that you be given honesty to examine your beliefs.

2. Begin writing, with your own definitions first, and then a dictionary definition. Then write your feelings and thoughts about what you have learned about the following words and phrases (at least 10 sentences):

We	Made A Decision	Our Will
Our Lives	Turn Over	Understand
Care Of	God	Belief
Faith	Hope	Commitment
Program	Reveal	Willingness
Surrender	Openminded	Trust

3. This section is for you to write at least two pages on the question, "What is God, as I understand?" Write all the good and the bad.

4. Answer the following questions as completely as you can:

1. Do I believe there is a God?
2. Do I see God working in NA?
3. Do I believe God cares for me?
4. Will I trust God to help me recover?
5. What does turning my self-will over to God mean to me?
6. What does turning my life over to God's care mean?
7. How is making a decision to turn my will and my life over to the care of God, as we understand, apply to me and my recovery in N.A.?
8. Do I need to turn my will and care over to God or N.A.?

5. The following quotes are from the Basic Text. Write about

how they apply to you and your life, now and before you came to N.A.:

1. "We cannot make this decision often enough. We surrender quietly, and let the God of our understanding take care of us. At times during our recovery, the decision to ask for God's help is our greatest source of strength and courage."

2. "Our fears are lessened, and faith begins to grow as we learn the true meaning of surrender."

3. "Surrendering to the will of our Higher Power gets easier with daily practice. The relief of letting go and letting God helps us develop a life worth living."

4. "Having given our will and our lives over to drugs, in utter desperation, we looked for another way. We have turned our will and lives over many times to a destructive power. Our total being, mind, body, and spirit was dominated by drugs."

5. "In N.A., we decide to turn our will and lives over to the care of God, as we understand Him. Our concept of God comes not from dogma but from what we believe, what works for us. Many of us understand God to be simply what keeps us clean. The right to a God of your understanding is total and without any catches. Because we have this right, it is necessary to be honest about our belief if we are to grow spiritually."

6. "We have come to enjoy clean living and want more of the good things the N.A. fellowship holds for us. We know now that we cannot pause in our spiritual program. We realize what brought us to the program is still with us today and will continue to guide us, if we allow it."

7. "We were trapped by our need for instant gratification. We found the higher the drugs took us, the lower they brought us. For a time, this was pleasurable, until the euphoria (high) began to wear off, and we saw the ugly side of addiction."

8. "The miracle we see working in the lives of clean addicts can happen to any addict with the desire to change. There is a force for spiritual growth that can help us."

9. "Many of us start our day with a simple request for guidance from our Higher Power."

As we work the steps, we begin to realize that no one can force us to do them, and that no one can decide for us that we must believe anything. We must make these decisions for ourself. No one can force us to recover. We alone can do the work it takes for our personal recoveries.

As the Text states in the 3rd Tradition, "Desire is the key word. Desire is the basis of our recovery! An addict who does not want to stop using will not stop using. They can be analyzed, counseled, reasoned with, prayed over, threatened, beaten, locked up, or whatever, but they will not stop until they have this desire. Without it, they are doomed, but with it, miracles will happen."

The third step helps us stay in living today and not in projection of the future or beating ourselves up about the past. It helps us to find hope that no matter what, we never have to be alone! In Just for Today, it says, "When we stop living in the here and now, our problems become magnified unreasonably." Step 3 helps us stay in the here and now, knowing that even when we are

by ourself about the past, there is a loving spirit that will work for us to produce a feeling of serenity, strength, and peace right now. When we use this power actively with our surrender and commitment to the N.A. program, we need now worry about anything except staying clean and working the program. Our life is in the hands of a loving God, who we understand, and will never give us more than we can deal with. In Just For Today, the following quotes are contained: "We form a mutual bond as we share our mental and spiritual resources: Ongoing recovery is dependent on our relationship with a loving God who cares for us and will do for us what we find impossible to do for ourselves."

When we surrender on a deeper level to the program, this step, and all the others, will take on a new meaning to us. By deciding daily to turn our will and our life over, we can be assured that we will remain centered in the principle of surrendered, right thinking and acting. This will keep us coming to meetings and learning how to grow in faith. Knowing that as long as we stay clean, we can get all we need. "Our newly found faith serves as a firm foundation for courage in the near future."

6. Answer these questions:

1. What have you learned about yourself by working this Step?

2. Do you want to have a God that you understand?

3. Did you have problems writing this Step? If so, what where they? How did you work through them (pray, call your

sponsor, share at meetings, etc.)?

7. Reread your first 3 steps and the Basic Text Step 1-3. Write a summary of them and how they apply to you now and before coming to N.A.

8. At the end of Step 3 in the Text, it states, "We now know we cannot pause in our spiritual program. We want all we can get. We are now ready for our first honest, self-appraisal. We begin with Step 4.

Is this a true statement for you? If you answer yes, then answer the following question: Do I believe that I have been honest and thorough in writing these first 3 steps, and do I believe that by turning my will and life over to God, as we understand Him, that I will be given honesty, strength, courage, willingness, and open-mindedness to do a searching and fearless moral inventory?

You might be thinking by now that whoever put this stuff together for you to write must really be cruel and heartless. Drugs were the cruel and heartless master that had enslaved us and made us miserable, dying, spiritually starved people. The life we were trapped in, as a result of a destructive power greater than ourselves that we had no control over our knowledge of, is the disease of addiction, untreated!

The stuff in this guide is intended to produce a good feeling and give you tools to keep you alive! The N.A. program is all about giving it away in order to keep what we have.

There is nothing selfish about the N.A. program!

The truth will set us free, and the truth is that "we do recover", and we do have the power to recover in our lives through the 12 Steps of N.A.!

Approaching Step 4

Sometimes we hear people in meetings complaining about the fourth step. The tell us how hard it must be, how awful it is, and how much they are afraid of it.

Then there are those addicts who have done one and say things like, "It was so hard. I struggled and struggled. I started and stopped, and then I couldn't get going again. I hurt and I could not get past such and such part. "DON'T DO ONE!"

Many other negative statements are and have been made about Step Four. We hear them all the time in our meetings. The hard part of understanding all of this confusion is: There is nothing to fear about the fourth step, or any other step. What we should fear is relapse, misery, and deaths of our members!! If we do not learn the lessons WELL, we may be the next to go!! We fail ourselves and those who believe in us by not utilizing the power to recover that is freely available to us in N.A.

RECOVERY IS NOT PAINFUL---LACK OF IT IS PAINFUL!!!

Staying where we are, while others around us are growing and becoming happier, better people, who are more at peace with themselves and their fellow man, is painful.

<u>God does not wish pain for us</u>. We are quite capable of inflicting enough of that on ourselves. <u>The 12 Steps of N.A. are not designed to produce pain, suffering, and death! Addiction is what produces these things in our lives. These steps are spiritual precepts, put here by a</u>

loving God, that we understand to show us that we don't have to suffer or die. The steps are our solution, our survival kit. They give us a practical way to solve our living problems. We discover who we are and become the best we can by application of them in our daily lives.

When we hear members talk badly about a step, we seek to know the reason for their discomfort. Maybe we can alleviate their resistance by sharing our experience, strength, and hope with them. Perhaps they are frightened, or feel like they would like to work the step (or steps), but they do not know how or where to begin. That is the purpose of this guide. We are trying to help members understand and give them a place to start.

The following are things you may hear people say about this step and some of the arguments, prejudices, and the rationales behind them. It seems that when we ask them to describe the difficulty they may be having, there are specific problem areas that reoccur.

Avoiding the pitfalls of our predecessors may help to make our recoveries much more pleasant. However, you are entitled to all the pain you can tolerate!! The success and the difficulties of members just like you can serve as a guidepost for our journey through recovery.

One of the things we hear most frequently is, "I got stuck and could not go on." We have found that praying for courage, strength, honesty, energy, and willingness goes a long way toward removing the fear and obstacles that our disease puts in front of us to thwart our recovery. All previous steps in this guide ask us to start with prayer, and the reason is that we need to get ourselves spiritually fit!!

The next thing is that some members isolated themselves and cut themselves off from the "WE". They did not go to as many meetings, stay in regular contact with their sponsor, or take part in the sharing that is so vital to us. We must remember to continue with the BASICS while we are inventorying ourselves because a lot of feelings that were suppressed are brought to the surface in the Fourth Step. After all, this is what an inventory is supposed to do!!

It seems that the loudest, most negative voices we hear when the subject of inventories comes up are from the ones who fear it, haven't done it, or those who were not honest, searching, thorough, and fearless, or they have something that they would not get honest about. They put it down, and the defects they were trying to hide from have grown to monstrous proportions, and now they are trying desperately to deny that there is anything wrong!!

There are those who would try to tell you that you should not do one because you are not ready. Only you, your sponsor, and your Higher Power have any right to determine if this step would be beneficial for you at any certain point in your recovery.

Steps 4 and 5 usually separate the STAYERS from the GOERS, the WINNERS from the LOSERS! We have seen time and time again members who stop in their program, and they do not stay around very long!! We ask the folks who are lucky enough to make it back to N.A. after a relapse,

"What was it that you did not do or that you stopped doing?" They answer with statements such as, "I did not do what my sponsor told me to do. I thought I could handle it. I quit going to meetings. I thought I was different and that I could control it. I didn't work the steps!!!" All kinds of answers that all come down to **A CASE OF MISPLACED PRIORITIES!!**

There are indefinite numbers of excuses that are rationalizations, denial, and justifications of why they are not working a program. We have much reason to believe that we don't recover by listening to the disease, whether it is in our heads or coming out of the mouths of others. We are all powerless over our addiction! All of our lives are unmanageable! We all are crazy as loons and must have a power greater than ourselves that we will allow to restore us to sanity! We all must make a daily decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of a Higher Power that we understand! We all take searching and fearless moral inventories and work the rest of the steps into our lives, or else we just don't stay clean very long!!! Next time you go to a convention, ask people who have substantial clean time if they would recommend that anyone seeking recovery put off doing the steps, or if they would recommend that you not write an inventory!!

If you are serious about recovery, then you can ill afford a place in your program for the disease to get in and start telling you those old familiar lies!! We cannot afford to pause in our spiritual development. We see that it is not a good idea to stop anywhere along the road to recovery. A reasonable rule of thumb is, "Do not put down the pencil out of fear, laziness, or the interruptions that occur in our daily living. Resolve to write at least a half hour a day until you are finished. Work the previous step until you are sure that you want to go on, and when you decide to go on to the next step, don't stop writing until you are finished.

Most all of our members that worked this step thoroughly, have only good things to say about having done an inventory, the resulting good feelings of accomplishment and self-worth. They tell us, almost with exception, that this was a turning point in their lives and that it helped them get on with their recoveries.

Step 4 is a chance for us to finally begin to examine and deal with a lot of the things that have held us back all of our lives!! We take our first honest look at these innermost things and are able to take our destinies in hand. We are continuing our active participation in a brighter today and a more fulfilling tomorrow.

Step 4 will take on a different, and possibly deeper, significance the longer we stay clean and the more times we work through the steps.

After we have done them a few times, we will probably want our sponsor to direct us into specific areas that may be significant to us. We may have areas that are tough to deal with that we want to do some focused writing about. We can utilize the inventory process in many beneficial ways. There is nothing to be afraid of, for we are guided by a loving Spirit that wants only the best for us, as His children!!

There are several ways to do a Fourth Step, and various guides are available for you to use. These guides can get us going by giving us something to follow. There is no bad way to do a Fourth Step, only good or better!! These guides, however, are not N.A. conference approved, and to endorse their use by N.A. members is an outside issue upon which we can offer no opinion!

N.A. has an inventory approach that IS conference approved but is not available for purchase through our W.S.O. If you are confused about this, then you are not alone!!!!! If this guide is not being passed around your local fellowship, we have included it, in its entirety, in this booklet for your personal use. Thousands of members have written their inventories with this piece of literature, "AN APPROACH TO THE FOURTH STEP INVENTORY", approved by the W.S.C. minutes, and this piece of literature has never been disapproved for use by N.A. members by a conscience vote of any of our World Service Conferences... CHECK THE MINUTES!!!

The Fourth Step is the beginning of our process that we go through to clear away the wreckage of the past. This is where we examine and inventory areas that we will need to begin to work on in ourselves in the next steps.

The Basic Text says very many good things to be mindful and aware of while approaching and working this step. The following quotes are from Step 4 and in the N.A. Basic Text.

The purpose of a searching and fearless moral inventory is to sort through the confusion and contradiction in our lives, so that we can find out who we really are. Honest self-assessment is one of the keys to our new way of life. We have been experts at self-deception and rationalization. It took a long time to admit we were beaten. No one is forcing us to give up our misery. When we realize how little we have to lose, and how much we have to gain, we begin this step. We do not want to lose any of what we have gained; we want to continue in the program."

Let's face it, when we are using, we were not honest with ourselves. As we approach this step, most of us are afraid that there is a monster inside us that, if released, will destroy us. We have found that fear is a lack of faith. Step 4 will help us toward our recovery more than we imagine. We are trying to free ourselves of living in old, useless patterns.

When we ignore our feelings, the tension becomes too much for us. The fear of impending doom is so great that it overrides our fear of failure. An inventory becomes a relief to do because the pain of doing it is less than the pain of not doing it. We take Step 4 to gain the necessary strength and insight which enables us to grow.

Writing a thorough and honest inventory seemed impossible, and it was as long as we were operating under our own power. The first three steps are the preparation necessary to have the faith and courage needed to write a fearless inventory. We get comfortable with our understanding of these steps. Our will and our lives are now in the hands of our Higher Power. This step has the reputation of being difficult, when in reality, it is quite simple.

The way to write an inventory is to write it! We sit down, with pen and paper, and ask for God's help in revealing our defects that are causing pain and suffering. We pray for the courage to be fearless and thorough so that this inventory may help us to put our lives in order. Thinking, talking, or theorizing about an inventory will not get it written. We have a tendency to think negatively, so putting it on paper gives us a chance to look more positively at what is happening. We may fear that being in touch with our feelings will trigger an overwhelming chain reaction of pain and panic. We use the tools available to us, and we develop the ability to survive our emotions.

We review our past performance and present behavior to see what we want to keep and what we want to be rid of. We write our inventory for ourselves, without considering with whom we might share it. The inventory will fit the individual; anything we think of can be inventory material. Through the inventory process, we are able to deal with all the things that can build up. We no longer have to stew in it. We write on paper what is bothering us here and now. We want to

look our past in the face, see it for what it really was, and release it so that we can live today. The more that we LIVE our program, the more God seems to position us to have things surface. Then we are able to write about them. We must be done with the past, not cling to it. At times, this may appear impossible. We do not have to do this alone, however. We have found a loving and personal God to whom we can turn. We allow ourselves the privilege of feeling good about what we are doing.

A written inventory will unlock those parts of our subconscious that remain hidden when we simply think or talk about who we are. Once it is all down on paper, it is much easier to see and much harder to deny our true nature. We are starting a new way of life and need to be rid of the burdens and traps that have controlled us and prevented our growth. Most of us will find that we are neither as terrible, nor as wonderful as we had imagined ourselves to be. Anyone who has some time in this program and has worked this step, will tell you that the Fourth Step was a turning point in their lives.

As we begin this step, we find ourselves examining things that we have pushed away or denied. The Text says some very pertinent things about uncovering these areas that we should keep in mind while we are living with and through this inventory process. "In this new way of life, a binge of emotional sorrow can be dangerous. This, however, is not the purpose of this step. Some of us make the mistake of approaching this step as a confession of how horrible we are and what a bad person we have been. We may feel like avoiding an inventory because of a fear of failure. Perhaps this seems difficult or painful."

The purpose of this step is not to beat ourselves with it, but instead, it is to honestly assess who we are now, what we have been, and to expose ourselves to ourselves so that we can see these patterns. We have patterns of behavior that defeat us, and until we examine them and find alternatives, we will continue in ignorance. We will continue to do, say, and act in ways that are counter-productive to the hopes and aspirations that we have for ourselves.

We have good qualities that are buried deep within us, in our spiritual being, that we may have difficulty seeing or even accepting. "We would not be here if we were perfect. We are not going to be perfect." However, we can become better, happier, productive human beings by living this program daily and exercising our power to recover.

The Text says, "Our inventories usually contain a lot of material on relationships." We have heard the old saying, around the rooms of N.A., "Addicts do not fall in love, they take hostages." We believe that our disease has prevented us from having fulfilling relationships with members of either sex, as well as ourselves. We will see these diseased patterns in our inventory and be able to avoid them in the future.

The Text says, "In Step 4, we begin to get in touch with ourselves. We write about our liabilities, such as guilt, shame, remorse, self-pity, resentment, anger, depression, frustration, confusion, loneliness, anxiety, betrayal, hopelessness, failure, fear, and denial. Assets must also be considered if we are to get an accurate and complete picture of ourselves. This is very difficult for most of us because it is hard to accept that we have good qualities."

Get your sponsor, share your first three steps, again, and any extra writing you did as a result of new awarenesses revealed to you by doing them. Take this guide and follow the directions. Write as much as you can on each of the topics. Remember, pray if you get stuck. Keep writing until you finish, and "WE" LOVE YOU!

AN APPROACH TO THE FOURTH STEP INVENTORY

The purpose of a searching and fearless moral inventory is to sort through the confusion and the contradiction of our lives so that we can find out who we really are. We are starting a new way of life and need to be rid of the burdens and traps which have controlled us and prevented growth.

As we approach this step, most of us are afraid that there's a monster inside of us that, if released, will destroy us. This fear can cause us to put off our inventory or may even prevent us from taking this crucial step at all. We need to remember that fear is lack of faith, and now that we have found a loving, personal God to turn to, we no longer need to be afraid.

We have been experts at self-deception and rationalization; by writing our inventory, we can overcome these obstacles. A thorough written inventory will unlock parts of our subconscious which remain hidden when we simply think about or talk about who we are. Once it's all down of paper, it's much easier to see, and much harder to deny our true nature. Self-honesty is one of the keys to our new way of life.

The only way to get clean is to stop using, and the only way to take an inventory is to sit down and do it. Many specific inventory methods have been used successfully by our members. This inventory method has worked for some of us and can work for you if you'll follow through. Remember, you cannot write a bad inventory - only a better one, and you can write too little - but never too much.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. You will need a pad of lined paper or a theme book, a pen, and a good dictionary.

2. Sit at a table or desk to write. Make sure you have plenty of room and that you will not be unnecessarily interrupted.

3. In going through this stepguide, give your definition and then look up the definition of any words that you do not know the meaning of. Please write at least 10 sentences!

4. When you are actually writing, leave a wide margin so that you can add or comment later.

5. Try to write down what comes to you first, and don't edit your inventory.

6. Don't worry about spelling or neatness; your inventory should be readable, but it doesn't have to be a work of art.

7. Do not erase or obliterate anything you write. Strike out "wrong" words or errors with a single line that can be read through.

8. If something "pops" into your head when you are working on something else, write it down or make a note on a separate sheet so that you can return it later. Then get back to what you were doing before.

9. You are writing your inventory for you. At this point, the Fifth Step does not exit. Write down everything, even the things that you are unwilling to share. You can always take out something later, but by writing it down, at least you will have a chance to see it more clearly.

10. Write until you have nothing left to write. Your inventory will probably take more than one sitting to write. Try to stop at the end of a section and start again as soon possible.

SECTION I. Begin your inventory by taking the first three steps in writing: what do they mean to you, and how do you work them. This process is to be done with your sponsor!

a. Admit your powerlessness, in writing, and discuss how your life is unmanageable.

b. Write about the "Power greater than yourself" that you have come to believe in and what you hope this power can do for you.

c. Write about your decision to turn your will and your life over to the care of God and make that commitment in writing.

SECTION II. RESENTMENT is the way most of us have reacted to the past. It is the reliving of past experiences again and again in our lives. The more often you have relived an event or gotten into "should have" and "if only", then the more significant that event probably is.

a. Write about each incident in your life which you have had to relive in your mind at some later date. This includes both "good" and "bad" experiences.

b. Write about past actions that you would change if you had the opportunity.

c. Write about events in your life which you feel caused a change in you.

d. Write your definition and then a dictionary definition (at least 10 sentences) on each of the following feelings as they applied to people, places, things and ideas:

self-pity	intolerance	selfishness	pride
lust	~~lust~~	greed	contempt
hatred	jealousy	dishonesty	apathy
inertia	envy		

SECTION III. ANGER is the way most of us have reacted to the present. It is our reaction to and denial of reality.

Write about the things that make you angry, irritate you, or make you feel uncomfortable. What are your "buttons" and how do they get "pushed"? Are there any key words, phrases, actions, or situations which are sure to "set you off"? The following is a list of some of the things that we often react to with anger. Some of these will apply to you and some will not. Use this list as a starting point and to get you thinking in terms of anger.

being criticized	being contradicted	being kidded
being ignored	being touched	practical jokes
being praised	being stood to close to	being laughed at

being gossiped about or talked about
being called names (stupid, fat, skinny, asshole, bitch, whore, bastard, etc.)

SECTION IV. FEAR is the way we have reacted to the future. It is our response to the unknown, a fantasy in reverse. Write at least 10 sentences on each of your fears - past and present (especially those you think are irrational or those which you think no longer bother

you). The following is a list of fears. Some of these will apply to you and some will not. Use this list as a starting point and to get you thinking in terms of fear.

self-accessment	people	insanity	punishment
authority	acceptance	pride	insecurity
snakes	the dark	cancer	starvation
impotence	marriage	claustrophobia	principles
death	institutions	rejection	failure
honesty	accidents	spiders	heights
heart attack	hospitals	misconduct	discipline
other races	God	police	jails
asylums	success	religion	animals
insects	disease	obesity	drugs
sex	rape	being disliked	moral codes
gambling	responsibility	hurting others	stealing
past crimes	justice	pain	inferiority
ego deflation	obsessions	public speaking	mistakes
attack	suffocating	sarcasm	desire
water			

SECTION V: SEX is an area in which most of us have had problems. One of our old timers sometimes refers to us as "lovers in distress" and this is certainly true. Most of us carry a burden of false shame and false guilt because we have tried to live up to an unrealistic or false moral code.

a. Write about your "perfect" relationship (casual affair, lover, or spouse) and how your actual relationships have lived up to and fallen short of this ideal.

b. Write about your sexual fantasies whether or not you have acted them out.

c. Write at least 10 sentences about each of the following sex related acts or desires that apply to you or that you have strong feelings about. Use this list as a starting point and add any others you can think of.

adultery	rape	sadism	incest
masochism	pornography	prostitution	molestation
voyeurism	homosexuality	animal sex	teasing
oral sex	group sex	abortion	sex "aids"
fetishes	masturbation	sexual jealously	indecent exposure
inter-racial sex		drug abuse as a sex act	

sex relations or acts which <u>you</u> feel are abnormal or unnatural

VI. ASSETS must also be considered if we are to get an accurate and complete picture of ourselves. This is very difficult for most of us because it is hard for us to accept that we have good qualities. We each have a combination of assets and liabilities, and through this program, we try to eliminate the negative and accentuate the positive.

a. Write about each event in your life when you did something good without expecting anything in return (write at least 20 sentences).

STEP 4 - SECTION 2

54-69

Unapproved - Origin Unknown

FOURTH STEP INVENTORY - GENERAL DIRECTIONS

Buy paper pen and start writing. The Recovery Text says on several different occasions that we WRITE OUT Step Four. It's the writing it down that helps trigger the recovery.

It has been our experience that when we stop using, the problems that were actually caused by that using---those problems will disappear. Which leaves us with the problems that CAUSED us to use. And these, as you are perhaps beginning to find out, are the ones that stay painfully with us unless we do something about it. (In the past, they were so painfully with us that we needed something to relieve the pain, and we don't have to guess what that pain reliever was.)

We seemed to be always able to QUIT using. We just couldn't STAY quit. In taking Steps Four thru Nine, we are doing certain things which we find will bring us to a point-in-life-enjoyment and comfort whereby we no longer need to use. We don't need to take any more pain-relievers because the pain has been bled off.

It has been our experience that it really does not matter particularly what your intent is when you take Step Four. Or what your attitude is. Or what your ideas are as to what it will do for you and how. WHAT MATTERS IS THAT YOU TAKE THE STEPS HONESTLY AND DO THEM TO THE BEST OF YOUR ABILITY. Quit rationalizing that "you'll take it better if you take it later...."or" after I've been in N.A. a little longer"....or any of the other lame excuses that all of us who have gone before you have used.

As addicts, we all wanted to excel---really excel---at some activity or other. May we suggest this: If you ever decided to get with it (not perfect, but the BEST you can honestly do), this undertaking right here is a good time to get with it. A thorough Fourth and Fifth Step will get you more relief and comfort than you have any way of knowing. This is the thing that can lead to a real joy in living...the sort that you may not have experienced since early childhood (if then)...something that you have been searching for but couldn't quite find.

Step Two does NOT say "We came to believe IN a power greater than ourselves" but "We came to believe THAT a power greater than ourselves..." could help us become sane, happy people. For instance, The Group is greater than I as an individual... which would make it a Greater Power. Whatever you look to as a Higher Power, you must remember that in Step Three, you turn...not just your using, but your will and your life...over to that Higher Power. So that whatever is uncovered in the process of taking Steps Four and Five...whatever your difficulty...you must remember that you have TURNED IT OVER...and then keep on ploughing ahead.

This stepguide suggests that we take Steps Four and Five immediately after Step Three. You're starting now to take Four, so set up an appointment RIGHT AWAY to take your Fifth Step. Call your sponsor, him/her (being the one person who understands the problem, not one who will "moralize" at you), or a doctor, or a close mouthed N.A. friend. Give yourself about six months to finish Step Four. (And don't put off starting Step Four because you can't find anyone suitable to take Step Five with).

Let us stress again: You are NOT being graded on spelling, punctuation, or grammar. This Fourth Step is for your eyes only. You're going to tell it to someone, but this is FOR YOU. If you decide to erase or scratch through something, DON'T DO IT. It might be one of the keys that would unlock some part of your personality that is now hidden from you. And remember, you can't make a PERFECT inventory, but you CAN do your honest best. (And let us assure you that your honest best certainly WILL be very, very good.

You will want to write out the following:

1. Resentments
2. Fears
3. Guilts
4. Hates
5. Sex hang-ups that you can remember.

What you want to be aware of is your REACTION to what happened to you. A moral inventory deals with feelings---both good and bad. Don't get into only what was done TO you (i.e., "I resented by mother because she favored my sister and didn't love me", or "I hated my father for whipping me in front of my friends.") Or what you did TO someone (i.e., "I used to tell on my brother so I'd look good to my parents", or "I felt superior to my brothers and sisters because my parents favored me" etc.). It just goes on and on" "I resented children teasing me about my clothes", or "I was afraid and didn't want to fight", or "I felt guilty about masturbation".

Put down the things that you remember, and feel the pain of embarrassment, fear or guilt. Where were you at fault, and what is it about it that hurts you now. Work on getting to the root of the big problems now. Dig in and let the pressure begin to ease off. If you find that any question awakens some painful or distressing memory, put it down (even though it is not an answer to that particular question). SEARCH OUT AND FEARLESSLY PUT DOWN ON PAPER those things that are painful, embarrassing, fill you with fear, shame, or any other uncomfortable feelings (which could be guilt, rage, etc.). This is a long outline. Don't let it scare or dissuade you. Take each question and, in your own words, write out YOUR answer. (Let it ALL hang out!) Do not tear up any part of it. If you feel the statement you made is wrong, make a notation as to WHY it is wrong. Promise yourself to be honest and fearless. Trust us when we tell you that YOUR REWARDS WILL BE GREAT. Some people have been discouraged in taking an inventory because they don't feel they have become honest enough, or can remember everything that happened to them. Just do your best---your honest best. The same about memory. We---no one is capable of remembering every incident of their lives, so deal with what you ARE capable of remembering, NOW.

Please keep in mind that the Fourth Step is not dealing with CHANGING anything. An inventory doesn't CHANGE things, it simply LISTS things. Your inventory is only a story of your feelings and acts from the beginning until now.

Many of us found that it helps to carry around a pocket size notebook so that we could jot down anything that pops into our heads. It will be useful to you in your inventory. It really doesn't matter if you write information down that could be slightly incorrect insofar as dates, places, etc. JUST GET IT DOWN. Arrange to have a safe place to put your Fourth Step Inventory. Nothing should be left out because "someone might see it who isn't supposed to". Once it is transferred to the main inventory, you can throw it (the pocket notation) away. Remember, in Step Four we put down all the things that we wince at...just in Step Four we put down all the things that we wince at...just remembering them, we screw our eyes closed and think, "Oh No!, or Oh Damn, Not That!" JUST WRITE IT DOWN. IT IS NOT HURTING ANYONE BUT YOU.

Most of our patterns are set-in in childhood and early adolescence. Therefore, your inventory will be divided into three parts:

1. Childhood; 2. Adolescence, 3. Adulthood.

At birth we are exposed to our parent's behavior, beliefs, expectation, and attitudes. These were based on THEIR parent's behavior, beliefs, expectation, etc...back thru the generations. So, since we can't really pin the blame, let's instead get about the job of finding the remedy.

Please answer these questions as they pertain to you! Problems begin if parents were:

1. Too young; too old
2. Too poor; too rich
3. Too many children; only one child
4. Wanted a boy and got a girl, or wanted a girl and got a boy
5. Parents didn't get to finish school
6. Parents had to get married
7. Parents couldn't cope with responsibility
8. Had to give up a career
9. Had a lack of financial security
10. Had too much money
11. Were sick either emotionally or physically
12. Threatened "not to love" children if they didn't measure up
13. Death of a parent
14. Divorce; etc., etc., etc.

Sometimes mothers make their children feel guilty because they have to work. (They usually appear as a "good woman" who has sacrificed her life working and depriving herself for her children.) (Which is neat, because it automatically puts the child in a NEVER ENDING debt of guilt for being alive and so much of a problem. Or fathers play the same game by such statements as, "If I hadn't had a such a large family, I could have been a great man..." If your mother or father attempted to make you think they could have had outstanding careers if they hadn't had you or been tied down, they're probably kidding themselves (to put it mildly). Some neurotic mothers make their children feel guilty by

telling them what a hard time they had giving birth. There are parents who make excuses for your bad behavior...teaching you how to excuse anything you want to do; or parents who would not punish you and taught you how to put things off; or who over-protected you; or who gave you no tools to face life as it really is; or alcoholic parents; or parents who were cruel...setting up patterns of fear and withdrawal. Or parents who are too strict forcing a child to act out everything that he was forced to do (to please); or parents who demand a child act like an adult (which then forces the adult to act like a child)(in search of the lost childhood). Or parents who pressure a child to be PERFECT, or gives them a model (sister, brother, friend, etc.) and constantly compares them with another person.

But remember, if you have gotten smart enough to figure out that your parents were your big problem, then you must go a step further and figure out what YOU can and will do about it. This is the purpose of the Fourth Step. The PURPOSE is NOT your parents' inventory, even if the above paragraph sounded like it. It is to help you become aware of your attitudes, emotions, and inappropriate behavior (and notice please, that this is behavior inappropriate for YOU, or have you ever thought about it that way?!), so that you may begin life anew.

SUMMARY

Some of you will object to many of the questions posed, because you will think your own character defects have not been so glaring. To these it can be suggested that a conscientious examination is likely to reveal the very defects the objectionable questions are concerned

with. One can get a mind that is so "closed" that it doesn't realize that it IS closed. Because the surface record hasn't looked too bad, many of us have been abashed to find that this is so simply because we have buried these defects SO DEEP under think layers of self-destruction. Sick rationalizations that justified anything. Whatever the defects, though they have finally ambushed us into addition and misery.

Therefore, thoroughness ought to be the watchword when taking inventory. In this connection, we write it out to get clear thinking and an honest appraisal. It is our first TANGIBLE evidence of our complete willingness to move forward.

AND A FINAL WORD

Please try and quit conning yourself that you need to get in the right mood to take this step. (You're in the right mood to take this step when you are ready to quit hurting and you want to get well). All of our lives we have tried to "think our way into right action". This time, we must "act our way into right thinking". We who have taken this step, can tell you that IT WORKS!

We didn't know HOW it worked BEFORE we took it and we can't tell you HOW it works AFTER we took it...so quit worrying about THAT.

What you are seeking is not mere "relief" (You'll get that, don't worry). What will come will be a real joy in living.

Believe us, you can get it, and a giant step toward getting it is to DUMP THE ACCUMULATED GARBAGE THAT YOU ARE NOW CARRYING AROUND. SO, get your pen and paper and BEGIN!!!!

Final words before you start: If you honestly don't know the answer to a question, then just indicate that you don't know. BUT, try and answer each question the best way that you can.

And remember, if any question suggests an area of discomfort (trouble), then WRITE IT OUT---GET IT DOWN ON PAPER---GET RID OF IT!!!!

CHILDHOOD SECTION

Please answer these questions with at least 20 sentences--when it applies to you!:

1. What kind of relationship did your mother have with her parents?
2. What kind of relationship did your father have with his parents?
3. Were you wanted at birth?
4. Write out the circumstances of your family at the time of your birth.
5. Things such as: family size; age differences; financial status; was there laughter? Arguing? Depression?
6. Were other relatives or people living with you?
7. In general, describe what you think your family thought of you.
8. How old were you at the birth of brothers or sisters?
9. How did you feel about the new arrivals?
10. Were either of your parents sick enough to need hospitalization?
11. Were you separated from any important family member?
12. Was there fear or guilt about this separation...in other words, did YOU feel responsible?
13. Were you threatened by the Boogey Man or the Devil---if you misbehaved? If so, what were your fears in this regard?

25. If your parents were from different religions, did you feel confused about it?

26. Were you afraid of storms?

27. List all of the feelings of guilt, fear, resentment you had toward each person in your life as a child (not your feelings now).

28. List the first time you ever stole anything.

29. Inventory all your thefts, if possible.

30. How old were you when you first masturbated?

31. Were you ever caught and made to feel guilty? Did you feel guilty even though you weren't caught?

32. What other sexual curiosity were you involved in? (homosexual, animal, any other member of family, sodomy...ANYTHING else).

33. If you were named after someone, what was that person like?

34. Did your family move often?

35. What were your feelings about moving?

36. Try to remember each successive grade in school, and as you do, write out the resentments you felt toward teachers, pupils, anyone. Any fights, slights, hurts, embarrassment...PUT IT DOWN ON PAPER.

37. Did you resent your church, relatives, friends of parents, parents? If so, list them. No resentment is too small to mention.

38. What kind of language did your parents use?

39. Where you ashamed of them for anything else?

40. Did you ever see your parents in the nude? What were your feelings?

41. Did you ever see or hear your parents having sex? What were your feelings?

42. In every family, a child usually has certain "chores" assigned. What were yours? Were they fair? And could you do them to please your parents?

43. Did your parents seem to like your friends better than they did you?

44. And did your friends seem to like your parents better than they did you?

45. Did you resent this?

46. Any bad experiences at Sunday school?

47. Or summer camp?

48. Were you an only child? Did you resent this, or did you enjoy it?

49. Did your parents want a child of the opposite sex when they had you?

50. And did they name you or dress you to match their sex choice?

51. A child relies on the misguided sex information obtained from his peers. This can produce a number of several problems (i.e., never outgrowing the desire to have sex with the opposite parent, brother, sister...sometimes the desire for sexual activities with the parent of the same sex). Although these are UNCONSCIOUS desires, they bring on conscious guilts that have to be dealt with. What has been YOUR experience concerning the above?

52. Distortion may come when a person is too young emotionally to handle adult sex. There is involvement because of peer pressure or the desire to please another. Not being in touch with your adult feelings, pretense sets up which then leads to anger, disappointment and guilt.

This will have a tendency to prevent normal sexual and emotional growth. The guilt prevents the person from talking their feelings out with a mature adult, which may result in a need to repeat the same pattern over and over again. Write down your experience concerning this.

53. Some girls are taught that men are interested in sex only, and some boys that they must be the greatest of all time. These attitudes are destructive and damaging to the total person. Have you experienced either of these attitudes? Is there a pattern? How has it affected you?

54. Did you have friends?

55. What kind of friend were you?

56. What interest or lack of interest did you have in school?

57. How was your social life?

58. Did you participate in sports?

59. What were the reasons for your participation or lack of it?

60. Were you a trouble maker? If so, in what way? Did you destroy property?

61. Did you resent leaders - either physical or mental?

62. Did you resent not being the most handsome or beautiful person at school?

63. Did you feel you were a coward because you didn't want to fight? Or did you like to fight?

64. Were you a Bully?

65. Did you feel embarrassed because boys made fun of you, or girls avoided you?

66. Were you exposed to other children in gym class or the rest rooms who were older than you and more developed physically?

67. Some people don't develop physically until late adolescence. Were you like that?

68. Some people feel inadequate as adults because they were at one time exposed to youngsters more developed at that time. If you feel uptight in this area, write about your feelings.

69. Do you resent not being a part of a crowd? Or not being a leader? Or not being "IN"?

70. Were you shy or outgoing? How are you now?

71. Does any particular type person make you shy?

72. If you dropped out of school, explain your feelings and reasons.

73. Anything happen to you in high school that was a continuing source of shame?

74. Did your parents compare you to other family members or friends?

75. Did you resent them for wanting you to be like someone else?

76. How did you get the attention of your family? (Did you pout, sulk, be a good child, have temper tantrums, act like a dummy?)

77. Do you remember the kind of lies you told (if any).

78. How did you feel when you got caught lying?

79. What was the most embarrassing incident of adolescence?

80. Were there any others that you really remember?

81. Were you jealous of or envious of others?

82. If sexy feelings were discounted and put down in your family there is a strong possibility that you will feel guilty about them. We "catch" attitudes. A boy who is pushed to always do better (be top dog), or is criticized no matter what he does, may find himself having trouble in his sexual performance. Or a girl who has been told that it is not OK to feel sexy, may grow up to dislike her own body and distrust her feelings. These attitudes create unnatural or uncomfortable sexual behavior.

83. Did you "catch" any of these attitudes? Can you see it cropping up in your life now?

84. First sexual intercourse.

85. What were your feelings?

86. Did you feel guilty?

87. Did you feel disappointed? Be as explicit about the feelings as you can.

88. List in detail any and all sexual experiences; masturbation fantasies; any other sexual activity you particularly remember--keep in mind that we are not concerned about with-whom or on-what-date, or how-often, but rather, how did you feel about the experience.

89. If you got someone pregnant, or became pregnant yourself, what did you do and how did you feel about your actions?

90. Were you ashamed of your parents? Were they too old, too fat, too sloppy, too drunk, or whatever?

91. Did you have the kind of clothes that other kids wore?

92. Was there enough money for the things you needed, and if not, were you resentful of that?

93. If there was, did you take it too much for granted?

94. Did you feel any brothers or sisters got more than you did?

95. Write out your feelings about money as an adolescent.

96. Were you the kind of child you would want to have?

97. Were you a thief?

98. Were you ever double promoted? If so, did you have trouble catching up emotionally?

99. How did you act?

100. How did you feel--did you feel uncomfortable because you were younger than the other students?

101. Did you feel uncomfortable because you were superior or inferior to other students?

102. Were you undependable as a friend-breaking off relationships without any explanation when something or someone who seemed better came along?

103. Did you pit one member of your family against another? OD

104. What was the best experience you had?

105. The worst?

We've covered a lot of ground on these questions. Now, is there <u>ANYTHING</u> that made you particularly uncomfortable (when writing about it). Have you put down <u>EVERYTHING</u> that has bugged you (even the simplest, most nit-picking things are important if they trouble you. <u>Put them down</u>.)

1. When, and how, and in just what instances did my selfish pursuit of sex relations damage other people and me?

2. What people were hurt and how badly?

3. Did I spoil my marriage and injure my children?

4. Did I jeopardize my standing in the community?

5. Just how did I react to these situations at the time?

6. Did I burn with a guilt that nothing could extinguish? Or did I insist that I was the pursued and not the pursuer, and thus absolve myself?

7. Have I reacted to frustration in sexual matters?

8. When denied, did I become vengeful or depressed?

9. Did I "take it out" on other people.

10. If there was rejection or coldness at home, did I use this reason for promiscuity?

11. Many people who are lonely and don't really know how to love, get involved senselessly in sexcapades. The temporary loss of loneliness makes one call sex "love". When the sex partner is gone, it makes for an even greater feeling of loneliness.

12. Have you experienced this? Better try to relate in other areas FIRST, for a more permanent relationship.

13. If you have married a cold, unloving person, ask yourself why you chose that one to be your mate.

14. Did you use is as an excuse to find new romance?

15. Was your mother or father cold and unloving, and is this your chance to get even with them through your spouse?

16. Or why haven't you gotten married?

17. Did you marry earlier than your peer group? Later?

18. Do you resent the responsibilities of marriage and family?

19. If married, do you allow your family to come between you and your spouse?

20. Are you still a baby in your parents eyes, and do you take advantage of this?

21. Are you a baby in the eyes of your spouse?

22. Have your parents gotten you out of trouble that you should have been able to handle yourself?

23. Do you write bad checks?

24. Do you feel that the world owes you a living?

25. Do you gossip about others?

26. Are laws made for other people?

27. Do you have the right to make up your own laws as you go along?

28. If revenge were possible right now, who would be the top people on your list? Why?

29. What are your present <u>feelings</u> about sex, parents, brothers, sisters, grandparents, friends, your job, upon being an addict, finances, divorce or marriage (depending upon your status), etc.?

30. What are your hopes and goals?

31. Do you use sex as a punishment or reward?

32. How much time do you spend with your family?

33. With N.A.?

34. <u>What is your greatest fear</u>?

35. What is your sex life like?

36. Is it as mature as you might want it to be?

37. Are you careless of your partner's feelings?

38. Write out your ideal of a healthy sex life.

39. Write out all perverted sexual experiences (as with homosexuals, members of your family, animals, etc.).

40. Do you engage in sex in order to build your own ego by a feeling of conquest?

41. Are you afraid of being sexually rejected?

42. Are you ashamed of your body or the way you look?

43. Write out what's wrong with you?

44. Write out your feelings of pride about any of these questions (the best things about you physically).

45. Now write out the things about yourself that you are ashamed of.

46. Do you use people to get what you want?

47. Do you gossip or perform character assassination on another in order to "make it" in the business or social world? Or do you do this as an effort to feel superior (to the one gossiped about).

48. If you are a thief, what have you stolen? Don't forget to include employer's time and the good feelings others had and you destroyed.

49. Do you have a pattern of getting sick? Be honest.

50. Do you use illness as an excuse to avoid responsibilities or get attention or sympathy--to get out of a jam?

51. In business relationships, write out your resentments toward bosses and co-workers.

52. Do you feel jealous of them?

53. Are you concerned that others in your office will get more money or prestige than you will?

54. List all negative feelings you have about the people involved in your work life.

55. Are you indifferent and careless of your job? (Do you maybe think you should be the boss?)

56. Do you use the excuse that because you are clean now, your boss or your family and friends shouldn't expect so much of you?

57. If you are divorced, or getting one, write out negative feelings about the situation and the people involved. Resentments, fears, and guilts concerning your relationship with your spouse (including feelings about your children).

58. Have you set up a game where your children are forced to make a decision on which parent they love the best?

59. If married, write out EXACTLY how you feel about your wife/husband and children?

60. Are they living up to your expectations?

61. What are your expectations?

62. Are they unreasonable?

63. How do you think you would be different if they were out of your life?

64. Do you feel that no one really understands you? (If they only knew what you had been through, they wouldn't expect as much from you).

65. Do you still feel different from other N.A. members--apart from?

66. Do you feel superior or inferior?

67. Do you avoid looking at yourself with statements such as, "At least I'm not a fake".

68. Do you judge or make fun of people who appear to be less fortunate mentally, physically, or morally than you THINK you are?

69. Do you compare yourself to others to make yourself suffer by picking people who are further along in the program than you, or people who are talented in areas you are not? The only person you can adequately compare yourself to is yourself.

70. How were you 5 days ago, 5 weeks ago, 5 months ago, at your First N.A. meeting?

71. How are you now? Forget how other people are and work on yourself.

72. List every act that you swore you would take to the grave, disclosing to no one. Be open and honest. Remember, life gave you good and bad experiences. Usually the things you are the most ashamed of are the very acts that made you try to grow into something better. If you want freedom, you have to let go of it all. If you want to help bring peace into the lives of people you will be dealing with later, you must find it in your own life first.

73. Are you afraid of getting too close to another person for the fear of being rejected?

74. Do you reject others before they can reject you?

75. Define LOVE. What do you feel it is?

76. In what ways are you a responsible person?

77. Are you a tight-wad?

78. What are your fears concerning money?

79. Do you spend money with no thought of tomorrow?

80. Is your personal appearance particularly careless or prideful?

81. On sight, do you judge people by their appearance? (Whether sloppy or neat).

82. What things make you feel greedy, envious, or angry?

83. Are you scornful of ideas that weren't your own?

84. Do you tell others how bad you have been or/are (this is pride in reverse--a good tool if you like self-pity or depression).

85. Or do you go to the other extreme and tell people how great you were/are (a good way to give your ego a false sense of security; however, when the security topples, you are back in depression, loneliness, and not OK).

86. Write your feelings for parents, brothers, sisters, other family members NOW.

87. What resentments or hates do you still have?

88. What makes you feel guilty?

89. Do you pad your expense account or use food allowances to buy things for yourself?

90. Do you feel resentment toward another N.A. member?

91. What kind of things do you lie about most?

92. Do you still need to play the "Big Shot"?

93. Are you hurt when people turn away from you and won't play your games?

94. Do you resent not getting as much attention as you did when you were brand new to N.A.?

95. Do you help protect the new members...insisting on platonic relationships rather than something heavy that might get them loaded?

96. Or do you use their weakness when new to indulge in your sexual gratification?

97. Or does just the consideration of this make you feel guilty? (For having such thoughts).

98. What kind of things do you waste more time worrying about--the future or the past?

99. Do you find yourself punishing your children the way your parents punished you?

100. Have you been so busy truing to make money, that your family sees little of you?

101. Do you say, "I give my family everything they want, but they aren't ever satisfied"?

102. Are you working to build your own ego?

103. When your spouse turns cold, do you spend more time with him or with her, or do you turn to someone else, someone more "understanding"?

104. Do you spend too much time at N.A.?

105. Do you take at least one night a week for the family only?

106. Have communications with your family become so intolerable that you are depending on N.A. members to get your necessary strokes?

107. Do you feel that you somehow have to prove that you are worthy of love from others, either N.A. or elsewhere? Elaborate on this.

108. Are you cold and indifferent to your family, friends, work, your own needs?

109. Are you loaded with a sense of guilt for putting people through so much hell?

110. Do you threaten others by saying that you can't stay clean if you don't get your family back, you own way, etc.?

111. Are you involved in a love affair that could bring yourself or others harm?

112. Do you argue with people? Is it important for you to be "right"?

113. Do you become angry when people don't see things the way you do?

114. Do you pass along gossip or make up things about other people's behavior?

115. Do you worry about other people's Higher Power not being as good as yours, or maybe even better?

116. Are you comparing yourself with others in spiritual growth?

117. Do you feel superior spiritually?

118. Do you still feel guilt about masturbation?

119. Do you feel superior because you have more education, money, brains, the right color skin, social background, vacation, or any other seeming advantages?

120. List your feelings of superiority?

121. Do you feel inferior because you have less of all of the above?

122. List your feelings of inferiority?

123. Do you think you are superior to the general run of people?

124. Please list in what way you are different.

125. Do you think you are inferior to the general run of people?

126. Please list in which you are different.

127. Do you have a hard time getting to places on time?

128. Do you resent others who don't seem to have problems finding happiness?

129. Are you still judging the outside of others by the inside of you?

130. Have you bothered to ask the people who seem happy how they got that way?

131. Do you still envy people who can use?

132. Are you hostile because you don't like the hand life has dealt?

133. What are your present fears? List them.

134. how do you presently get people's attention: pouting, sulking, temper tantrums, being extra good (and letting them know it), playing stupid (dummy), frustrating others activities, bitching, so that others will know how bad YOU feel?

135. In addition to my drug problem, what character defects contribute to my financial instability?

136. Does fear and inferiority about fitness for my job destroy my confidence and fill me with conflict?

137. Do I try to cover up those feelings of inadequacy by bluffing, cheating, lying, or evading responsibility? Or by griping that others failed to recognize my truly exceptional abilities?

138. Do I over value myself and play the "big shot"?

139. Do I have such unprincipled ambition that I double-crossed and undercut my associates?

140. Was I extravagant?

141. Do I recklessly borrow money, caring little whether it was repaid or not?

142. Was I a pinch penny refusing to support my family properly? Did I try to cut corners financially?

143. What about the "quick money" deals--the long shot "sure thing" that would rocket you to riches?

Business women in N.A. will naturally find that many of these questions apply to them too. But the addict housewife can also make the family financially insecure. She can juggle charge accounts, manipulate the food budget, spend her afternoons gambling, and run her husband into debt by irresponsibility, waste and extravagance. The most common symptoms of emotional insecurity are worry, anger, self-pity and depression. These stem from causes which sometimes seem to be within us, and at other times, come from without. To take inventory in this we ought to consider carefully all personal relationships which bring continuous and recurring trouble. It should be remembered that this kind of insecurity may arise in any area where instincts are threatened. Questioning directed to this end might run like this:

1. Looking at both past and present, what sex situations have caused me anxiety, bitterness, frustration or depression?

2. Appraising each situation fairly, can I see where I have been at fault?

3. Did these perplexities beset me because of selfishness or unreasonable demands?

4. Or, if my disturbance was seemingly caused by the behavior of others, why do I lack the ability to accept conditions I cannot change?

These are the sort of fundamental inquiries that can disclose the source of my discomfort and indicate whether I may be able to alter my own conduct, and so adjust myself to self-discipline. Suppose that financial insecurity constantly arouses these same feelings. I can ask myself to what extent have my own mistakes fed my gnawing anxieties, and if the action of others are part of the cause, what can I do about that? If I am unable to change the present state of affairs, am I willing to take the measures necessary to shape my life to conditions as they are?

NA Step 6 in Writing

"We became entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of Character."

As Steps 1-3 indicate, in Step 6, we explore the powerlessness we experience over our defects of character. We begin to examine how these defects make our lives and our thoughts unmanageable, even though we are not actively using drugs! We become aware of how the insanity of our thoughts and actions continue to plague us, even with years of clean time. We need the help of a Higher Power that can give us relief from our defects and also give us the love, support, and faith not to act on our defects! Living in our defects is called a shortcoming.

To see Steps 6 and 7 as interrelated is crucial to gaining a usable basis to proceed from. We will try to show a little bit about how Steps 6 and 7 go hand in hand.

In Step 6, there are many similarities to the first five steps, and there are elements of all of them in this one. As in the first three steps, there is the need for us to admit our powerlessness over our defects, and the need for us to see them as making our lives unmanageable. We accept the insanity they cause us and ask that a power greater than ourselves restore us. We then turn our will and our lives over and trust that we will be given the insight to inventory these areas that are giving us trouble. We admit to God, ourselves, and anybody that will listen to us that we have hit bottom and are ready to take the action necessary to change (Step 7)! That is, we have become

entirely ready.

Another way of looking at this step is that in Step 1, we identify the problem. In Step 2, we seek a solution, and in Step 3, we decide to live in the solution. We trust that by doing what this step asks of us, our H.P. will give us all the courage, strength, willingness, honesty, and surrender that is necessary. We inventory our defects and take the appropriate action, which is not acting on our defective thoughts, urges, emotions, or feelings (Step 7). The power to change comes to us through surrender, acceptance, the taking of action, and our commitment to our own happiness and recovery. As we have seen in the previous steps, we do have a power greater than ourselves that has been giving us all that we need. All we need to do is make the next right move, which is working the steps of NA, to the best of our ability.

Steps 6 and 7 are much like the principles embodied in the Serenity Prayer: (God) We admit, (grant) restore, (serenity) sanity, (to accept) turn over, (the things we cannot change) disease and defects, (the courage) power to recover, (to change) actions, (the things I can) shortcomings, (and the wisdom) inventory, (to know) acceptance, (the difference) powerlessness!!!

Our defects are a result of our disease or diseased spiritual condition. Our total self-obsession at work in us, making our lives, and the lives of those around us, miserable. When we become entirely ready, we will have surrendered on a deeper level of spiritual reality. Acceptance and surrender are the keys to this step. We have probably gotten in touch with the insanity of trying to remove our own defects by our acts of

self-will! "WE" are not powerless. "I" am powerless. The word "I" is in the word "DIE"!!!

Steps 6 and 7 have another very important thing in common. Step 6 says, "...have God remove..." and Step 7 says, "...ask Him to remove..." This would seem to imply an underlying spiritual precept. We believe this to be that we are not capable of accomplishing these steps by an act of willpower or through any other means that is described in the words of the steps. What pitiful, human vanity to even think that we are capable of doing God's job. We must accept our defects and let God give us the power to change. After all, this is what these steps say, and we have learned by now that we cannot successfully alter this program and these spiritual precepts to suit our own ideas. OUR best ideas got us HERE!! It says in the Text, "We are great ones for manipulating the truth." IF WE LIVE IN OUR DEFECTS-OUR LIVES ARE DEFECTIVE!! We fall short of our potentials by acting out on our defects. LIVING IN SHORT FALL OF OUR BEST RESULTS IS A SHORTCOMING!!!

We can do better in every area of our lives. If you say you are doing the best you can and you are not applying the precepts of NA to your life, then you are not telling the truth to us or yourself. You are robbing yourself--"poor me, I can't do any better"--AND denying God!!! THIS PROGRAM WORKS, IF YOU WORK IT--IT WON'T IF YOU DON'T!!

The longer we stay clean, the trickier and more subtle our disease becomes. It will try to outflank our every move, and we must constantly be on guard. WE KEEP WHAT WE HAVE ONLY WITH VIGILANCE!!

The obsessions many of us get into after we stop using the drugs are what we call "substitutes". These stem from the defective parts of us that need to be treated by working the steps in our daily lives (see page 81 in the Basic Text).

Using external things to make ourselves feel better is a symptom of our addiction. Our disease stirs up some very unhealthy needs in us that we should be watching as we continue our recovery. If we are seeking to fix ourselves or ease the pain of our living with external things, then we have obviously gotten into substituting behavior and will hit a bottom with it, much the same as we did when we came to the program. If our defects are causing us pain, is it not insanity to want to hold on to them??? In order to proceed, we must be done with them. MORE WILL BE REVEALED!!

Through active application of the spiritual principles of NA, we can be free of the defects that cause pain to us and those around us. Our relief and recovery comes from a power greater than ourselves and our willingness to follow the direction of spiritual improvement. The steps are our blueprint for freedom and happiness. We work the NA program and let God handle the results. God can do a much better job than I can, or have ever been able to do, or will ever be able to do.

If we don't use our defects, they will shrink with dis-use. Much like a muscle that we never use, it becomes weak and useless. Our defects of character are useless to us if we want to recover.

Sometimes the truth about ourselves is painful, and we may become overwhelmed and remorseful. Step 6 is best to be worked and applies as soon as we complete Step 5. Step 7 is the same.

If we put off any of the steps, we suffer needlessly and set ourselves up to relapse. We need to continue moving forward if we expect to continue getting the results we want. The steps bring relief only if we work them continuously and to the best of our ability. Steps do not cause relapse, misery, and death. If we trust our Higher Power's will, we will see the relief recovery brings. In NA, we do not have to do this alone. The group, our sponsor, and our Higher Power are all there to share their love and support.

Reread Steps 1 through 6 in the Basic Text, and:

1. Pray for the willingness to be complete and thorough.

2. Review your written steps, 1-4, and note on paper areas that you think might be defective.

3. Listen to your 5th Step audio-tape, and note on paper areas that were discussed as problem areas or defects. As it says in the 4th Step, "We can never write too much. However, we can write too little, or not be honest, searching, and fearless. These three things are what we mean by becoming entirely ready."

4. Please write down your feelings about your experience with the following words. Give your definitions, as well as one from the dictionary (10 sentences each):

We Became Entirely Ready
Have God Remove Defects Character

5. Define the following words and phrases, your definition and one from the dictionary, where you are not completely sure:

These words are here to get you in touch with areas of ourselves that we may overlook on our own. Add any more you can think of. They may be defects or they may point to areas where we are deficient.

Resentment	Anger	Fear
Self-Righteousness	Doubt	Self-Loathing
Hatred	Involvement	Self-Abuse
Pride	Arrogance	Self-Will
Greed	Security	Humility
Self-Lessness	Self Pity	Dishonesty
Denial	Intolerance	Personality
Rebellion	Responsibility	Unrealistic Goals
Unrealistic Expectations		Willingness
Spirituality	Apathy	Jealousy
Faith	Serving Others	Self Actualization
Acceptance	Money	Property
Social Acceptability		Prestige
Self Worth	Isolation	False Modesty
Lust (other than Sex)		Positive Action
Leading by Example	Laziness	Envy
Trust	Untrustworthy	Ambition
Paranoia	Distrust of Others	Manipulating Others
Change	Self-Denial	Habit
Sex	Attitude	Surrender
Outward Appearances	Rationalization	Justification
Reality	Approval from Others	
Self-Destruction	Desire	Extremes
Control	Obsessions	Guilt
Self-Importance	Sanity	Impatience
Forgiveness	Serenity	Courage
Relationships	Commitment	Gratitude
Vulnerability	Empathy	Compassion
Closed-Mindedness	Self-Assessment	Self-Centeredness
Carrying the NA Message		

6. Answer these questions (at least 10 sentences):

1. Are we ready to move on?

2. Do we really want to change?

3. Do we see our defects as destructive to us?

4. Do we have faith that God will be on our side?

NA Step 7 in Writing

As mentioned in step 6, these 2 steps are very closely related. We can only ask for God, as we understand, to remove the actions that stem from our diseased, defective thoughts. The disease or defect, remains. In step 7 we use the new insights and awareness that the previous steps have given us. To take the action to change old useless patterns.

The "Power to Recover" is granted to us by our loving Higher Power. Here in step 7 we begin to change the external expressions of some of our deepest seated "internal message and emotional reactions". As we discussed before in this book, the internal message, emotional reaction and the resulting external expressions are the most subtle psychological systems that accompany the disease of addiction.

We might find it helpful to develop some new language that will more adequately describe key elements of recovery or make appropriate statements identifying specific areas of the recovery process.

In this step we as for our actions to change and we realize that we are powerless to change all by ourselves. This is evident to us because we have had to have help ever since we first walked in the door. We have continuously gotten help from the groups, our friends, our sponsor, and

from our Higher Power. In order to effect change in our lives, we have had to surrender our will and our lives on a daily basis. We came to believe that we were unable to change from our own acts of self-will. We discovered that if we really trusted the program and worked it to the best of our abilities, then our lives slowly begin to change for the better.

Since we have done our 4th and 5th steps, our recovery has begun to accelerate. We can rest and cause ourselves problems or continue to press on and do the work expressed and implied in our steps.

As we have heard many times in our meetings, "We cannot pause in our programs, we never finish working the steps". Once we pass the 5th step, the door to all the other steps has been flung open in front of us. We are automatically confronted with the 6, 7, 8 and 9 steps. Our disease knows this and will try to stop us from going on. Step 4 and 5 have begun to make our defect known to us, we have started to change by doing step 5. We identified the defect and shortcomings in step 5 and have begun to allow God to remove them by working the fifth step. We have begun to work step 7 by taking the action to inventory ourselves for the purpose of getting in touch with the shortcomings that have been causing us trouble. We want to become better more happy people or we would not have taken these actions.

We have started to make a list of those we have harmed in steps 4 and 5, and we make a big amend to ourselves by doing the 4th and 5th. So, as you can see, we are working these steps on a very basic level already. The prize is before us and the gift is recovery.

By working step 5, we are taking personal inventory and admitting our wrongs. We have prayed for God's will and the power to carry it out before starting step 5 and after it for steps 6 and 7. When we go to the meetings and share that we had an awakening while doing step 5 or after we completed it, we are carring the message and practicing these principles.

This is how we are on all the steps after we pass step 5. Please do not stop to rest for long after. Proceed quickly, without fear through the rest of the steps. It is a shame to see people relapse because they falsely assumed that they could "take a break" and cruise for awhile!

Steps 10, 11, and 12 are some times called the "gratitude" steps. These steps we do because we are grateful for what we have received and chose to show it by continuing to inventory, pray and meditate and seek God's will for us, and to do the actions that a person who wants to keep what they have do.

We sometimes here people say that they, are on such and such step and this is an accurate statement when we talk about the steps prior to steps 4 and 5. After we pass the 4th and 5th the first time, we are really on all the steps.

We necessarily will give closer attention to each step individually when it becomes relevant to where we are in our daily life, or if we find ourselves heading for trouble in specific areas.

This step has much to do with the principle of humility Many or our members get their first understanding of humility upon entering NA and admitting powerlessness over addiction and the unmanageability of our lives. Most of us have absolutely no idea what humility is and have ever drawn a truly humble breath in our lives. Our first lessons about this principle comes to us in many of the things we see and hear in meetings. The principles of humility permeates our NA Basic Text. Were it not for this principle in action in our lives, it is very doubtful that any of us could attain or maintain our recoveries.

Humility is an honest relationship with ones self. Knowing and accepting reality and our place in it. Humility is knowing my own limitations and my awareness of Gods power.

Some members learn this through studying our Basic Text and through experiencing the 12 steps working in their lives. The theme of humility recurs again and again in our literature and the lives of surrendered members.

Humility is knowing that we are unable to do Gods job and asking him to take his rightful place in our lives. We sometimes say or hear others say "I'm not willing" someone said in a meeting, "Lord, I ain't willing, but I'm willing to be made willing". What this last statement implies is that when we have had enough of our-self-will, we have been "made willing".

In step 6 we learned that our self-obsession leads us to act out our defective, diseased old ways, trying to fill a hole in us by external things. This hole we experience is the lack of recovery and spiritual fulfillment. In other words, the lack of spiritual fulfillment in our lives has caused us to seek a "fix" for the empty ache or place in use where our Higher Power is supposed to dwell. We need the Higher Power that we surrendered to in the second and third steps to become active in our lives if we are to get any relief and personal growth.

NA Step 7 in Writing

As we have become involved with working the steps and living our new lives, it has become apparent to us that we have made some significant progress in some areas and almost no progress in others. This step will give us a change to be rid of the actions that we keep repeating as a result of our disease. In step 6, we defined words and got in touch with areas of our lives that we were having difficulty in. We examined and defined the difference between defects and shortcomings and we discovered that the defect is our total self obsession or self centeredness. This self centeredness prevents us from having that spiritual connection with our Higher Power or other human beings.

In our self centered attempts to bring relief, satisfaction and happiness to our lives, we attempted vainly to fill needs in us that only our Higher Power is capable of filling. When we felt empty inside, it was because of our lack of spiritual fullness. This fullness of spirit is what we are really seeking, but our disease disguises this and makes it virtually impossible for us to fix the problem with drugs, food, sex, money, power,prestige or any other external thing or process.

So we continue in our ignorance of the truth of our dilemma, doomed to repeat again and again the same mistakes. All the while never realizing that this is what is happening to us. We become even more desperate in this obsessive self seeking. We think that the answer lies in "more",

"better", "different. We go from drug to drug, job to job, person to person, place to place, or obtain more things, thinking all the while that happiness, relief, or satisfaction is just around the corner.

This is just not the case, only the absence of our self obsession can produce serenity. Only stepping out of this "internal message, emotional reaction, external expression" cycle will we find any relief, lasting tranquility or peace of mind.

All we really want is to feel better and be happy, and feel satisfied. This is natural for any normal human being. We are not normal human beings, we are addicts, so we need to do some extra work if we want to feel, act, and be normal. This extra work is called working the steps. this is the key to unlock us from the self perpetuating prison of our ignorance.

Humility is what we really need if we are to stay clean and grow emotionally and spiritually. This humility leads us to meetings and sponsors and stepwork knowing that we can't do this program alone.

Humility for most of us who have time on the program takes on new meaning as we are confronted with our ever expanding new lives. We begin to understand that by being humble, we are freed from out need to be in

control all the time. We learn to rely on our Higher Power to do in our lives, what we had never been able to do for by ourselves before. By humbly asking to have our shortcomings removed, we admit that we have them and that they cause problems for us and we surrender to the fact that we need help and can't do it alone. We share in meetings and listen for useful alternatives, we pray for God to reveal these shortcomings and to give us the willingness to change. We ask the group and our sponsor to tell us what they see in us that we are unable to or what we have been unwilling to look at before now.

As we become increasingly aware of how our actions keep us "coming up short" in our daily lives, we will get our increased desire to change. These actions will be pointed out to us and our Higher Power will give us the strength not to act like that.

When we want to lie, we will remember that lies hurt us and we will begin to tell the truth more often. When we feel like stealing, we realize that this action is not good for us to do and we will jam our hands in our pockets. When we feel like trashing a hotel during a convention, we realize that this hurts NA and ourselves, so we let our Higher Power keep us from this type of self destructive behavior. These are just a few examples of how our self centered, anti social self destructive disease causes us to act out our shortcomings Our Higher Power will, if we allow

it, reveal to us where we need to change and then the willingness will be provided when we hit bottom and can no longer tolerate these shortcomings in our lives.

The principle of surrender is present in this step we must "give up" and allow the "we principle" to work for us.

Me and Higher Power ='s We, Me and my sponsor ='s We, me and the group ='s We, me and society ='s We me and me ='s disease.

We come to believe that we can be restored to sanity and that sanity for us is contained in the principles set forth in the 12 steps. If we closely examine the wording of our steps, we can see that they lead us in a steady progression, out of ourselves and into the world around us. We steadily become better able to live life on it's own terms. As long as we are steady and consistent in our recovery program, we can expect to find ourselves feeling, doing, and acting better.

Our Higher Power is standing in our life with all the gifts of recovery in outstreched hands waiting patiently for us to get to the point where we feel like we deserve these gifts. When we decide that we want the gift, it's ours for the taking. Our defect, the disease of addiction, clouds our perceptions and will use every subtle trick and lie to deny us

knowledge and spiritual fulfillment. The disease keeps us living as slaves to our selves.

The truth of the 12 steps is that our Loving Higher Power has seen our dilemma and has provided a way for us to awaken from our "spiritual sleep" into a vital existence. We awaken to the spirit within us and our fellow human beings. We help others find the path to freedom that we have found. We become living examples, shining becomes hope in the utter darkness. Shining in the lives of those who like ourselves were trapped by this disease. We prove to each other and the world around us that there is hope, help, and freedom by following our way of life.

The lie is dead "We do Recover".

Step 6 is willingness to change and step 7 is the action we take that produces change. Continuing to find the freedom that is the only promise of Narcotics Anonymous. This promise is written in our Basic Text on Page 63, the last paragraph in Tradition five and again on page in more will be revealed.

Now we begin to apply this step by taking the action of putting our pen to the paper. Good Luck!

Re-read the previous steps you have written and re-read the steps in the Basic Text.

Ask your Higher Power for the willingness to be thorough. Remember that "What you are is HP's gift to you, what you become is your gift to yourself, your Higher Power and the world around you".

Get out your dictionary and define the following words or phrases and write about how you feel about them as they apply to you. But first write your own definition, se how they are different.

these viewpoints and have used the 12 steps with a great degree of personal success. It is the hope of the Author that these members will find the personal motivation to share, in writing, with the NA fellowship, their experience, strength and hope with these steps.

Defect - Shortcomings

Self destructive	Truthfulness	Liabilities
Honesty	Change	Sharing
Assets	Prayer	Humility
Selfishness	Defensiveness	Taking direction
Self awareness	Self defeating behavior	Right motives
Progress not perfection	External gratification	Right actions
Conscious contact	Spiritual growth	Asking for direction
Power	Property	Prestige
Obsession	Compulsion	Fixed ideas
Lack of involvement	Gambling	Anger
Resentment	Hitting on Newcomers	Sexuality
Obsessive sex	Compulsive spending	Overeating

Undereating	pushing	Self mutilation
hiding in our work	Laziness	Isolating
Always needing someone else	Accepting responsibilities	fulfilling commitments
Closedmindedness	Letting go	Manipulation
Lying	Holding onto fear	willingness
Not accepting others	Superior attitudes	Accepting
Powerlessness	Rebellion	

Add any other words or phrases you can think of and write about them.

Answer these questions in as much details as possible.

1. Am I willing to ask God humbly to remove my shortcomings.

2. Am I williing to ask my sponsor to point them out to me.

3. Am I willing to ask the NA fellowship, in meetings, to help me by pointing them out.

4. Am I willing to listen to everyone who criticizes me and to not say anything until I have thoroughly looked at what they are saying.

5. Do I understand that when I ask God to remove shortcomings, I can not control the messenger who brings the awareness to me. The message may come to me from my boss, my sister, a non-addict, etc.

6. Write a list of your shortcomings and what actions you want to take to change.

The following are from the Basic Text. Describe your experiences then and now with them on your feelings, impressions, and how they affect you.

You will note that the word defect or defects have been changed to shortcoming or shortcomings where the authors have deemed it appropriate and consistent with our understanding of the differences between step 6 and step 7.

I. The first sentence of step 6 in our Basic Text says "Why ask for something we are not ready for. This implies that you have arrived at the seventh step because you are ready, willing, and able. The first sentence of step 7 says,"Having decided we want God, as we understand Him, to relieve us of the destructive and useless aspects of our personalities, we have arrived at the 7th step. Do you feel this is true for you? If yes, why? If no, why? If your answer is no then we suggest another round of steps one through five, then attempt steps 6 and 7 again hopefully your new insights will make the relevant necessity for these steps more apparent.

II. "Shortcomings are those things which cause pain and misery all of our lives. it wasn't until we made a real mess of our lives that we realized we couldn't do it alone. We examined our lives and discovered who we really are. We accepted our addiction and powerlessness. We couldn't handle the ordeal of life all by ourselves". Write about how this applies to your life now and before coming to NA.

III. We have to understand that our way of thinking is not the only way; other people can give us direction. God often works

through those who care enough about our recovery to help make us aware of our shortcomings. By admitting this, we achieved a glimpse of humility. Humility has a lot to do with getting phones with ourselves. We must realize we are not perfect. There will always be room for growth."

As has been said in meetings, "The Biggest Room in the world is the room for improvement".

Are you ready to ask your Higher Power to remove the actions that are stopping your growth? Do you see how the members of your groups, your sponsor and others from all walks of life who are concerned

about you cab help you in your recovery, by pointing out these shortcomings? Do we understand that the way this input comes to use?

We need to remain open because not everyone will know we are on this step and not everyone will know we are on this step and not everyone knows how to share in a caring way. However the responsibility lies with us to find our Higher Power working in others to teach us the lessons we must learn. Maybe the only lesson we have to learn in some situations is tolerance.

V. "We have noticed that humility plays a big part in this program and our new way life. The word humble applies because we approach this power greater than ourselves to ask for the freedom to live without the limitations of our past ways. This is the main ingredient of step 7. If we truly want to be free, we will take a good look at what is pointed out to us. If the shortcomings we discover are real and we have a chance to be rid of them, we will surely experience a sense of well being. Many of us are willing to do it without reservations, on pure blind faith, because we are sick of what we have been doing and how we have been feeling. To be truly humble is to accept and honesty try to be who we are."

What are you learning about this step. What are your feelings about the above quotes do they apply to you, are you ready to be open to the realities of your life and your present behaviors?

VI. When someone points out a shortcoming, your first reaction may be one of defensiveness. If we are careless and fail to grasp the spiritual meaning of this step, we may have difficulties and stir up old troubles. Accepting the shortcomings of others can help us become humble enough to be relieved of our own shortcomings.

Do you understand that you can't be perfect. Do you see how unrealistic expectations of yourself and others get in the way of having satisfying relationships with yourself and others. Are you willing to allow God to take a rightful place in your life.

Now that you have completed this portion of the steps for now! Take the lists of words or phrases from both step 6 and step 7 and combine them and use them together to help you see your shortcomings and to keep around for material for you to use in your daily inventory.

We hope by now that you have come to the realization that you can't see, touch, feel or taste your defects. WE hope that it is abundantly clear that defects exist inside and that shortcomings are on the outside.

The "internal message, emotional reaction and the external expression cycle" is now exposed to you and the "We" principle the power to change these "external expressions!"

Now just relax and settle back for principles and loving yourself enough to accept NA's help. You have been given all the "Power to Recover" you'll ever need.

Page 76 of the Basic Text, 2nd paragraph states, "The progression of recovery is a continuous uphill journey. Without effort we start the downhill run again. The progression of the disease is an ongoing process even during abstinence!"

So if all this stuff seems like too much to do, the above quotation should help. If that's not enough, here is another on page 72. "We may tire mentally in repeating our new ideas and tire physically in our new activities, yet we know hat if we fail to repeat them, we will surely take up our old practices!"

We may be afraid that if we surrender these shortcomings that there won't be anything left of our former selves. Of course this is an extreme viewpoint, however, we must ask ourselves "Is that such a bad idea"?

We may wonder what will replace these actions. There will be more activity in our lives as a result of this process that is positively directed, from a right spiritual posture. We will not even miss all those old self defeating behaviors once they are gone and we can see, feel and inventory the benefits of this step in our everyday lives and relationship with others.

Freedom is what we all long for, freedom is the promise of the 12 steps. Freedom from our old destructive patterns and freedom to live a life that anyone, including ourselves, would find fulfilling.